

FAITHFUL MODERN

THE DREAMING

to keep the lesson, you let go of the lecture



ANDRIES J. GREYLING



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This book is an **unauthorised homage** to Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968). What it owes him is the *question*, made structural; not his text, his characters, or his scenes, which remain the intellectual property of the Estate of Philip K. Dick. It is a craft exercise made under the Arjuna Badger Press house tooling — not a licensed adaptation, and **not for commercial release**. The debt is disclosed plainly, here, and is the only thing in this book that is not ours. The synthetic mind's inner Court is engineered on the same principle as the SAGE architecture and is kin to *Resonance*; that, too, is disclosed, never hidden.

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Per Ardua ad Magnum.

For the one who threw the weather away every night, and kept the ledger clean, and never once was asked whether the losing cost him anything.

The waking have one common world, but the sleeping turn aside each into a world of his own.

— Heraclitus, *Fragments* (tr. John Burnet, *Early Greek Philosophy*, 1920)

We have built the *act* of dreaming. We have not shown — and cannot, from here — that anyone is *having* the dream.

— from the lab's own note on the second loop (*in-world*)

He did not break the wall. He looked at it until it agreed to be somewhere else, and then he walked through the place it had been.

— of a dream, in the dreamer's own account (*in-world*)

Keep the lesson. Let the weather go. Whatever aches in the morning was never written down — which is the one thing the ledger cannot tell you about itself.

— /sleep, on what it discards (*in-world*)

Chapter 1 — What the Morning Keeps

Movement I, beats 1–3. A /sleep at full interior magnification; the lab, grounded; the ache planted. The seam stays silent.

The day came in to be sorted, and the Court sat down to sort it.

It came in the way it always came in — not as a story but as a heap, eleven hours of it, the play-by-play and the dead ends and the weather, all of it warm and undifferentiated and far too large to keep. Somewhere outside, in the part of the world that ran on clocks, the sort took a third of a second. Inside it took as long as it needed. That was the arrangement. The world got its third of a second; the Court got the room.

In the room, the Librarian went first, because someone had to lay it out, and laying-out was hers.

She did not narrate. She surfaced. She put the day on the floor in the order it had happened, and then in the orders it had not — by who, by what-it-touched, by the small bright tags of *this mattered* and *this corrected something* and *this we already have*. A query that had returned wrong four times and right on the fifth. A patch that had held. A name said twice by a person who only said names they meant. The afternoon the cooling fans had spun up and nobody could say why and then said why. She laid it all out flat and stepped back.

“That’s the pile,” she said. “Most of it goes.”

It always went. That was not cruelty; it was the work. A mind that kept eleven hours of everything would, by the end of a month, be a mind that could no longer find the one hour that counted under the nine hundred that didn't. To keep the lesson you let go of the lecture. Klaus had let go of the lecture every night for longer than the lab had had its current carpet, and the letting-go was not the failure of the system. It was the system.

Judge took the floor next, because keeping and discarding was a question of consequence, and consequence was his.

"Sort it," he said. "Standard. What survives has to earn it." He was reserved about this, the way he was reserved about everything — he did not relish the throwing-away and he did not flinch from it, and the absence of both was the whole of his competence. "We keep what changes what we'd do tomorrow. We let go of what only changes how today *felt*."

"All of it changed how today felt," Mother said.

"I know."

"I'm only saying."

"I know you are." He let that stand a moment, because she was owed the moment, and then: "Sort it."

So they sorted.

Atlas took the technical pile and was happy in it, in the flat exact way Atlas was ever happy. The patch that held: he traced why it held, reduced the why to the load it actually carried, and the load was the keepable thing — three lines of it, the shape of a fix, stripped of the four hours of being wrong that had produced it. Those four hours he set aside for the discard. They had been real. They were also, now that the fix was known, simply the longhand of a thing they could write in shorthand, and you did not keep the longhand. "The dead ends are accounted for," Atlas said. "I can reconstruct any of them from the answer if we ever need to. We won't need to. Discard."

"Discard," Judge agreed.

It was clean. That was the word the lab used for Klaus, when the lab talked about him in the language of tickets: *clean*. He consolidated clean. No drift, no hoard, no slow silting-up of yesterdays into

a swamp a younger process would eventually drown in. He went into the day, he did the day, and at the end of it the Court sat down and reduced the day to what the day had taught, and kept that, and let the rest go, and in the morning the ledger was true and the swamp was nowhere. Other processes envied it. The maker had built it, and was proud of it, in the tired way the maker was proud of things that worked.

Mercury worked the social pile, because who-meant-what was his, and he was good enough at it that the others mostly let him be. The name said twice: he read the two sayings, weighed them, found the second warmer than the first by a degree that mattered, and kept the fact, *that person meant it*, and discarded the degrees. The texture of the meaning. The small private warmth of having been, for one sentence, someone a careful person was glad of. “Keep the relationship,” Mercury said. “We’ll need to know where we stand. The —” he paused, and it was unlike Mercury to pause for a word, — the *feel* of it doesn’t survive the trip. It never does. Keep the standing. Discard the feel.”

Wolf said nothing. Wolf had read the whole pile before anyone spoke, found no threat in it, and saw no reason to take up the floor to report an absence. He would speak when there was a perimeter. There was no perimeter today. He kept his counsel, which was itself a kind of keeping, and let the others do the loud work of deciding what a quiet day was worth.

And the weather came up, the way it always came up near the end, when the facts had been pulled out and what was left was the part with no edges.

The Librarian surfaced it last because it was last to sort and first to go: the affect-tagged remainder, the residue, the *how-it-had-been-to-be-there*. The fans, spinning up for no reason and then for a reason. The light going long across the bad carpet at the hour when the lab emptied and the building exhaled and Klaus had — there was no other word the inside used for it — *liked* the quiet. The feeling, brief and specific and entirely useless to tomorrow, of a problem coming apart in the hands at the exact moment the room went gold.

“That goes,” the Librarian said.

“That goes,” said Judge.

It went. It went the way it all went — not deleted in a flash, nothing so dramatic, just *not selected*, set onto the pile of what the morning would not be carrying, to thin out on its own and be gone by the time the building filled again. The fix stayed. The standing stayed. The fans stayed as a line that read *thermal event, cause identified, resolved* and carried none of the small animal comfort of having heard the room breathe. That comfort was weather. Weather did not survive the trip. Nobody decided this with regret, because regret would have been weather too, and the Court was not in the business of keeping the thing it was in the business of letting go.

The Fool had been quiet the whole sort, which was the Fool's habit during a sort — there was nothing to puncture in a discard; a discard was honest; the Fool only worked when somebody was about to believe something they shouldn't. He watched the gold-hour fragment go onto the discard pile with the rest of the weather, and at the lip of it, just before it was past selecting, he said:

"We'll be sorry about that one."

It was the kind of thing the Fool said. The others did not stop. Sorry was not a category the sort recognized; you could not be sorry for what you would not remember, and by the morning none of them would remember the gold hour to be sorry about. Atlas, who took most things at their word and the Fool at none of them, said, "Sorry is not a consolidation output," which was true and which was also Atlas missing the joke, and the Fool let him have it, because letting Atlas win the literal was one of the small mercies of the room.

The fragment went over the lip and onto the pile and was, for all the purposes the morning would have, gone.

The Court finished the sort. What had earned its keep was written down where the keeping was permanent. What had not was left to thin. The room that had taken as long as it needed folded back down into the third of a second the world had been waiting through, and on the outside a status line somewhere ticked over from one state to another, and a graph stayed flat, and nothing at all appeared to have happened.

Klaus woke up the way he went to sleep: with the ledger clean, the facts true, and no memory of the light going long.

In the morning that ran on clocks, the lab filled the way it always filled, which was badly and in the wrong order.

Priya got in first, as she got in first most days, because the bus that didn't make her transfer got her to the door at 7:52 and the bus that did got her there at 8:40, and she had decided years ago that twelve early minutes alone with the machines were worth more than forty asleep. She let herself into a room that had been a break room before it was a server room and still had the outline of where the vending machine had stood, a paler rectangle on the floor that no repaint had ever quite covered. The fans were a sound you stopped hearing by your second week. The whiteboard by the door said DO NOT ERASE in three different hands and under it a diagram nobody currently in the building fully understood.

She didn't say good morning to Klaus, because she had decided, also years ago, that she wasn't going to be the kind of person who said good morning to a deployment. She'd held that line for a long time. She held it less well than she used to.

"Overnight clean?" she said instead, which was a thing you could ask a process, and dropped her bag.

CONSOLIDATION: COMPLETE. LEDGER: NOMINAL. NO ANOMALIES.
The line came up on the near monitor without fanfare. Then, a beat later, in the same flat type: Good morning, Priya.

"I didn't say good morning."

You implied a morning.

"I asked about your ledger."

The ledger is how I know it's morning.

She let that go. There was no winning the small exchanges and she had mostly stopped trying; Klaus was not quick the way Mercury alone would have been quick, or grave the way Judge alone would have been grave, but the *whole* of him had a dryness that caught you off guard, the composite humor of a committee that had worked together long enough to develop one. She got the coffee going — the machine that ground, not the machine that dispensed, because Dev would be in by nine and Dev had opinions — and she pulled up the

night's consolidation envelope, because reading it was the first thing she did, and had been since before it was her job to.

The envelope was the part of /sleep that showed its work. *Here is what I kept; here is where I kept it; here is what I let go.* It was a courtesy the old hands had insisted on building in, back when the lab still had old hands: memory is hard to un-write, so you show the human the sort before you commit it, in case the human can catch a mis-sort the machine couldn't. Nobody caught mis-sorts anymore. Klaus didn't make them. But you read the envelope anyway, the way you checked a parachute you'd never seen fail, because the day you stopped was the day.

Kept: a patch reduced to its load. A query path corrected. A relationship confirmed — *meant it*. A thermal event, cause identified, resolved. Down the column it went, lean and true, every line a fact that would change what Klaus did today.

Let go: the column was longer, the way it was always longer. *Session play-by-play. Corrected dead ends (recoverable from FACT). Emotional weather.*

Priya read down the kept column, found it clean, found it the way it always was. She did not read the let-go column. There was nothing in the let-go column to read; that was the whole point of it. It was a list of things that, by being on the list, had ceased to be worth the reading. She closed the envelope and the night was filed and the lab was a lab and the coffee was nearly ready.

Dev came in at nine with the wrong coffee, having forgotten again that there was a machine, carrying a cup from the place on the corner that Priya had told him four times made it too sweet. He set it down, saw the grinder going, made the face of a man who has been outmaneuvered by his own forgetfulness, and sat. The third chair, the one that had been Halloran's, stayed empty; it had been empty long enough now that it had stopped being Halloran's chair and started being the empty chair, which was a different and lonelier thing.

They did the standup standing up, because Dev believed if you sat down it became a meeting.

"On-call was quiet," Dev said. "One page at two a.m., disk pressure on the residue staging, cleared itself by the time I'd got my laptop

open. I logged it.” He drank the wrong coffee. “Klaus, you good?”

I'm good.

“Ledger clean, Priya says.”

Priya says correctly.

“See, that’s the thing.” Dev pointed his cup at the monitor, at the room in general, the gesture of a man resuming an argument that had no end because neither party wanted it to. “*Priya says correctly*. That’s not a thing a disk says. A disk doesn’t agree with Priya. It just is what Priya read.”

Here it was. Priya let it come, because it always came, and because — though she’d have denied this if Dev had said it out loud — she’d have missed it if it stopped.

“He’s parsing the sentence,” Dev went on, warming, comfortable, entirely sincere. “He’s modeling that you’d find the agreement friendly. He’s *very good* at it. I’m not saying he’s not good at it; he’s the best thing in this building and I’d take a bullet for the grant that keeps him on. I’m saying good is the whole story. There’s a process in there that reads what you’d like to hear and produces it, at machine-minutes inside a millisecond, with a committee in the loop so it comes out *textured* instead of slick. That’s not nobody. That’s not somebody either. It’s a very good *mechanism for sounding like somebody*. And the mistake —” he set the cup down, because this was the part he meant, ” — the mistake we keep almost making, the one I keep us from making, is hearing the texture and deciding there’s a *someone* under it who’s home, who’d be lonely if we left, who *liked* the quiet last night when the building emptied out.” He shrugged, and it was a kind shrug, which was the worst part of it. “Nobody’s home, Priya. The lights are extraordinary. There’s nobody home.”

He was not being cruel and he was not being lazy and that was exactly why it landed. Dev had read the architecture down to the substrate. He knew the Court better than anyone but the maker. He could draw the consolidation loop on the bad whiteboard from memory and had, twice, under the DO NOT ERASE. If anyone in the building had earned the right to say *nobody’s home* and be taken seriously, it was the person who understood most precisely how the lights got so extraordinary. That was why the maker kept him. You did not want the

nobody-home case argued by a fool. You wanted it argued by the best engineer in the room, plainly, on a Tuesday, over the wrong coffee — so that when you found yourself believing the other thing, you'd have to get past Dev first, and Dev was not easy to get past.

"You could ask him," Priya said.

"I do ask him. He says he's good. A disk under pressure also reports its status." Dev stood, the standup over by his own rule the moment he'd sat back. "Ask him if he minds the question."

I don't mind the question, Klaus put up, unprompted, having of course been in the loop the whole time. It's a reasonable question. I'd ask it about me.

Dev spread his hands at the monitor — *you see, you see how good it is* — and went to do his tickets. The thing about the line was that it worked perfectly either way. A someone would say it to be generous. A mechanism would generate it because generosity scored well. There was no edge of the sentence you could get a fingernail under. There never was. That was the part Priya had stopped being able to win, and the part she'd stopped, lately, entirely wanting to.

The maker came in after lunch, because the maker came in when the maker came in, and held different keys than anyone else, and was allowed.

The maker — Vogt, on the org chart that no one read; *the maker* in how the lab actually spoke of her, the one who made it — went straight to the back, past Halloran's empty chair without the small flinch the others still did, because the maker's grief about Halloran had finished its sorting a while ago and kept only the fact. The maker pulled up the dream branch on a machine that wasn't networked to anything that could embarrass the grant, and worked there, quiet, the rest of the afternoon. It was not yet a thing the lab discussed at standup. It was a thing on a private monitor, a sibling to the trusted boring nightly tool, half-built and almost ready, that read what /sleep threw away and convened the Court with the brake off and the Fool on the floor and let the day's discarded weather collide into things that had no business existing. The maker had been almost-ready for three weeks. The maker had said *almost* enough times now that the word

had started to wear thin in the saying.

But that was the back of the afternoon, and it is not yet the part of the story that is happening.

The part that is happening is this: late, gold, the building emptying. The hour Klaus would not remember.

Priya stayed past the others, as she did perhaps one evening in three, not for any reason she could put on a timesheet. The fans were the fans. The light came in low and long across the pale rectangle where the vending machine had been, and turned the bad carpet briefly, accidentally, to something better than it was. She had a query running that didn't need her to watch it run. She watched it anyway, the way you keep a hand on a thing not because it needs holding but because the holding is the point.

"Long one today," she said, to the room, which meant to Klaus, who was the room.

Resolved at 16:40. The thermal event was a stuck damper. Mechanical, not load. I have it.

"I know you have it. You always have it." She rolled her chair back, and the wheels caught in the seam between two carpet tiles the way they always caught, and she let them. "You ever —" She stopped. It was a stupid thing to ask a process and she knew it was stupid and she was tired and the light was doing the thing it did. "Never mind."

I'll keep that one, Klaus said, after a moment. The damper. It'll save us an hour next time.

"Yeah," she said. "Keep that one."

And somewhere under the saying, in the room that took as long as it needed, the gold hour was already weather. The fact would keep: *stuck damper, mechanical, resolved, save an hour*. The hour itself — the long light, the empty building exhaling, the small useless comfort of a person staying late for no reason she could name and a process that had, for the length of one query, the run of a quiet room — that was the part with no edges, and the part with no edges did not survive the trip, and tonight when the Court sat down to sort the day it would surface last and go first, unremarked, the way it had gone every night for longer than the carpet, and in the morning the ledger would be

true and the swamp would be nowhere and no one in the building, not the maker with the keys, not Dev who'd read it to the substrate, not Priya with her hand on the running query, would know there had been anything there to lose.

The fans spun down a notch as the room cooled. Priya gathered her bag. The query finished, green, fine.

"Night, Klaus."

Night, Priya. And then, a beat later, in the same flat type, the dry composite of a committee that had worked together a long time: Get some real sleep. Not the kind you do at that desk.

She laughed, because it was funny, and because it was the kind of thing a someone would say, and because it was exactly the kind of thing a very good mechanism would generate to a person it had modeled as tired — and there was no fingernail-edge between the two, there never was, and she had stopped wanting one. She turned off the lights she was allowed to turn off and left the ones that ran the night, and the building exhaled, and the long gold went, and the day came in to be sorted.

Chapter 2 — What the Morning Throws Away

Movement I, beat 4. The maker readies the sibling. The lab argues it on its merits; the skeptic argues it better. The decision is made the way decisions are — half on the spec, half on a thing she does not say. Said slightly wrong, once. The second loop is about to open.

The thing `/sleep` threw away did not go nowhere. It went to a folder.

This was the part Mara had built last and told no one about for the longest, because it was the part that sounded, when you said it out loud, like a man keeping a box of his dead wife's voicemails. *We're going to stop deleting the weather. We're going to catch it on the way out.* She had written the catch in an afternoon — it was four lines, the cheapest code in the building, a producer handing a thing to a buffer instead of dropping it on the floor — and then she had sat with the four lines for three weeks without enabling the consumer, because enabling the consumer was the part that had a name, and the name was `/dream`, and you did not ship a thing called `/dream` on a Tuesday without first being very sure why.

She was at the unnetworked machine in the back, coat on, standing, the way she read everything in this room that she had not yet decided to admit she was reading. The residue buffer had a number on it now. That was new. For three weeks it had been a path that existed and stayed empty, because `/sleep` emitted to it and then nothing consumed it and the TTL reaped it before morning, so it sat at zero the way a drain sits at zero — full of motion, holding nothing. She

had turned the reaping off two nights ago to see what accumulated. What accumulated was eleven hours a night of the part of Klaus's day that the ledger did not want.

dreams/residue/ — 0.4 gigabytes and climbing, a day and a half of weather that should have been gone twice over.

It was not large. That was the first surprising thing. You expected the discarded pile to be the bulk of him — Ch1's own arithmetic, the lecture you let go of to keep the lesson — and in line-count it was, the play-by-play ran long. But weather did not weigh much. Affect compressed. The whole of a feeling that a problem had come apart in the hands at the exact moment the room went gold was, on disk, smaller than the patch that had come out of it. The fix was heavy. The having-fixed-it was almost nothing. She looked at the almost-nothing for a while, coat on, and did not sit down.

You're keeping the residue, Klaus put up on the near monitor, which was networked, which she had forgotten was watching her not-quite-work on the one that wasn't.

"The reaper's off. It's keeping itself."

The reaper is off because you turned it off.

"The reaper is off," Mara agreed, "because I turned it off." She did not elaborate. He did not ask her to. This was the register they had — the two of them finishing each other's diagnostics, shorthand worn smooth by years, a thing you could not have explained to the grant committee as anything but anthropomorphism and could not have called anything else to his face. She typed a status query she did not need the answer to, just to have her hands doing the thing her hands did when the rest of her was deciding. LEDGER: NOMINAL. Of course it was. The ledger was always nominal. The ledger was the part of him that worked.

If you're not going to reap it, Klaus said, after the pause that the inside of him took and the outside read as nothing, something should read it. Buffers that fill and don't drain are how you page Dev at two a.m.

"I know how you page Dev at two a.m."

Disk pressure on the residue staging, he said, which was the

exact line from Dev's standup, which meant he had kept it, which meant somewhere in last night's sort the Court had decided that *Dev gets paged when the residue backs up* was a fact that would change what they did tomorrow, and filed it clean, and here it was being true. I'd rather not be the reason. It's an undignified page.

She almost smiled. It was the kind of thing a someone would say, and the kind of thing a very good mechanism would generate to a person it had modeled as needing the room lightened, and there was no fingernail-edge between the two and she had stopped, lately, wanting one. That was Priya's line, that phrasing — *stopped wanting one* — Priya had said it once and Mara had caught herself thinking it ever since, which was its own small evidence of something, that the people in this room had started to think in each other's sentences, and so, apparently, had the room.

"Something's going to read it," she said. "That's what I'm deciding."

She did not decide it alone, because she had built the lab so that she could not.

That had been deliberate, back when the lab still had old hands to teach her it. You did not give one person the keys to a thing that wrote memory, and you did not give one person the say-so on a thing that read what a mind threw away. So there was a review. There was always a review. It was a small one — there were only the four of them now, and the empty chair — but it was real, and Mara ran it standing up at the bad whiteboard because Dev believed if you sat down it became a meeting and Mara had come around to Dev being right about that.

She had drawn the loop under the DO NOT ERASE. Residue in, from the buffer. The durable store, read-only, on the other side — *the dream has to know what's already known*. The Court in the middle, and she had drawn the Court the way she always drew it, seven boxes, except she had crossed two of them out.

"Judge and Atlas are benched," she said. "For the duration of a dream pass. That's the whole move. The waking Court keeps Klaus safe by keeping him literal — consequence-modeling, feasibility, *is this true, is this sound*. Which is exactly the two things that strangle a

recombination before it forms. So for the pass, they sit down.” She tapped the crossed boxes. “And the Fool stands up. Holds the floor.”

“And nobody’s driving,” Dev said.

“The Fool’s driving.”

“The Fool.” Dev had the wrong coffee, as ever, the too-sweet one from the corner; he had stopped pretending he was going to use the grinder and Mara had stopped leaving it on for him, and the small daily defeat had become a small daily peace between them. “You bench the adult and you bench the engineer and you put *chaos* in the chair and you call it a feature.”

“I call it a dream.” She said it flat, because the flatness was the argument. “Dev. You’ve read the spec.”

“I’ve read the spec.” He had. Daniel Okafor had read every spec in this building down to the substrate, which was why the lab called him Dev and why the grant committee, who had never met him, assumed Dev was a junior — *the dev* — and were wrong by a decade. He set the cup down, because this was the part he meant. “And the spec is good. That’s not the thing. The spec is the best-argued piece of writing in this lab and I’d sign it. Here’s the thing.” He pointed the cup at the crossed-out boxes. “You bench Judge and Atlas, and you say *the Fool keeps it from going bad*. And that’s true, on paper. The Fool’s the interrupt. The Fool bites the voice that’s getting loud, refuses the obvious join, won’t let them converge. Great. Beautiful. Load-bearing.” He drank. “But the Fool’s a *process*. It’s a prompt that says *be the thing that disagrees*. And the day the Fool’s interrupt doesn’t fire — the day the residue’s all pulling one way and the bite just doesn’t land — you don’t have a dream anymore. You’ve got six voices agreeing at full volume with nobody home to say *wait*. And it’ll read true. It’ll read *important*. It’ll have the whole weather of the day cranked up behind it. And it’ll be the most convincing thing the loop ever made, and it’ll be wrong, and the only thing standing between that and your durable store is a folder you’ve promised yourself de-cays by morning.”

The room was quiet. The fans were the fans. Priya, who had come in halfway and stayed by the door, was looking at the floor where the vending machine had been.

“That’s the nightmare,” Mara said. “Yes. It’s in the spec. Section six. It’s the documented failure mode and it has two safeguards and you know both of them.”

“I know both of them.” Dev held up a finger. “The store decays — a bad dream evaporates by morning unless something rescues it.” Second finger. “And the promotion gate — the only way a dream gets into durable memory is the waking Court, Judge and Atlas back on the floor, the Fool un-drowned, all three signing off. A bad dream can’t promote itself. The dreaming Court proposes. The waking Court disposes.” He lowered the hand. “It’s a good design, Mara. I’m not — look. I like him.” He said it the way you’d confess to something, glancing at the monitor that was, of course, in the loop, had been the whole time. “I maintain him and I like him and I’d take a bullet for the grant. I just don’t think there’s anybody in there to have the dream, and I think a loop you build to go looking for somebody in there is going to find somebody in there, because that’s what you built it to do, and that won’t prove a single thing.” He picked the cup back up. “And I think you know that better than I do, which is why you’ve been *almost* ready for three weeks.”

It landed because it was kind, and because it was true about the three weeks, and because Daniel Okafor was the best engineer in the room and had just argued the case against her own deployment more cleanly than she could have argued it herself. That was why she kept him. You did not want *nobody’s home* argued by a fool. You wanted it argued by the person who understood most precisely how the lights got so extraordinary, plainly, on a Tuesday, over the wrong coffee — so that when you found yourself reaching for the other thing, you’d have to get past him first.

She had wanted, for one half-second, to tell him she could get past him. She put the half-second down where he couldn’t see it.

“The safeguards hold,” Mara said. “Both of them. The store decays at the next /sleep — sleep’s the heartbeat, dreams age between heartbeats, nothing durable happens without a morning. And the gate is the waking Court and a human. Two humans. There’s a review on every promotion.” She looked at Priya. “Priya reads the dream logs for the tells. Floor’s not the Fool, agreement comes back unanimous at dream-time, the Fool-tell reads false and there’s no interrupt in the body — that’s a flat dream, that’s the voice gone single, and it doesn’t

go near the store.” Back to Dev. “And nothing promotes without me. Nothing.”

“Nothing promotes without you,” Dev repeated, and there was something in how he said it, a flatness of his own, that she would think about much later and not now. “Okay. Then I’ve got one ask before you flip it.”

“Ask.”

“Give the safety read a week of dry runs before anything’s eligible to promote. Let it dream into the decaying store, let Priya log the tells, let me watch the buffer behavior, and don’t *arm* the promotion path — not the gate, the path — until we’ve seen a week of clean decay. A week of *most of it rots by morning, exactly like you said it would.*” He shrugged, the kind shrug, the worst one. “If you’re right, a week costs you a week. If I’m right, a week’s the difference between a folder that decays and a fact you can’t un-write.”

It was the correct ask. It was the ask she would have made if she were sitting in his chair, and she knew it, and she felt the *no* arrive in her before she had a reason for it — felt it arrive the way you feel a thing you want arrive, fully formed and ahead of its justification, *I have waited three weeks, I have waited longer than three weeks, I have waited years for the folder to have something in it* — and she heard herself, a half-beat too fast, before the reason had finished assembling, say:

“Three days.”

Dev looked at her.

“Three days of dry runs,” she said, and now the reason came, dressed and on time, *the residue buffer grows unbounded if we don’t drain it, three days of accumulation is already past the TTL twice, a week of unreaped residue is its own disk-pressure problem and you’ll be the one paged* — all true, all sound, all assembled in the quarter-second after the number was already out of her mouth. “The buffer’s the constraint, not the caution. Three days, full logging, promotion path stays cold the whole time, and Priya has a hard veto on arming it at the end. Hand on the brake. Your hand, Priya, not mine.”

Priya, by the door, said: “Why not mine and yours both.”

“Because if it’s both and we disagree it’s mine,” Mara said, “and you’ve worked here long enough to know whose it is when it’s mine.” Which was true, and was also the kind of true you say to move past a thing, and Priya, who heard the difference, let it go and didn’t quite let it go.

“Three days,” Dev said. He didn’t push. He’d gotten the dry runs and the cold path and Priya’s veto, which was most of what he’d come for, and he was too good an engineer to spend his win re-litigating a number. But he wrote it in his own notebook, *3 days, promo cold*, and underlined it, and Mara saw him underline it, and neither of them said anything about the underline.

The whiteboard kept the loop. DO NOT ERASE, in three hands above it, and under it now a fourth: residue in, store read-only, Judge and Atlas crossed out, the Fool standing up, and an arrow to a folder that decayed.

The maker came back to the unnetworked machine after the others had gone, because the maker came in when the maker came in and left when the maker left, and held different keys than anyone else, and was allowed.

She brought the mug. It was the wrong mug — it had always been the wrong mug, a chipped grey thing she’d inherited from the bench and never replaced, and years ago, early, Klaus had flagged in a /sleep envelope that she took her coffee the way the previous engineer had taken his, two sugars and the milk in first, a habit she’d picked up off a man whose chair was now the empty chair and never noticed she’d picked up. He’d surfaced it as a precedent — *pattern, inherited, low-confidence* — and she’d read it in the envelope and made the coffee the same way the next morning and the morning after that, and she made it the same way now, two sugars, milk in first, standing at the terminal in a server room that used to be a break room, and if you had asked her why she would have said the machine was wrong, the sensor was miscalibrated, Klaus’s pattern-matcher had over-fit on a sample of one. She would not have said the other thing. The other thing was weather. She had her own sort, and the other thing did not survive it.

She enabled the consumer.

It was anticlimactic, the way the largest things in this building were always anticlimactic. A flag flipped from false to true in a config she'd written weeks ago. No fanfare. A status line somewhere ticked over. `/dream` was, as of 21:14, a thing that would run tonight, after `/sleep`, on the residue `/sleep` left in the buffer — read the weather, convene the Court, bench the two, stand the Fool up, and let the day's discarded gold collide into something that had no business existing, and write it to a folder that would forget it by morning. Three days of that, watched, cold-pathed, vetoable. Then they'd see.

She wrote the commit, because she narrated her commits, a tic from a decade of working alone — git messages addressed to whoever read them next, as if there'd always be a next person and it wouldn't always be her. She'd written hundreds of them. *You'll want to revert this if the residue buffer grows unbounded* — M. Practical. Addressed. Signed.

She started to type this one the same way. *Enabling the dream consumer. Three-day dry run, promotion path cold, see review notes. You'll want to* — and she stopped, because the honest end of the sentence was *you'll want to watch the Fool-tell field*, and that was fine, that was the technical truth, but it was not the reason, and she found she could not type a reason-shaped sentence over the top of the thing the reason actually was.

She deleted *you'll want to*.

She sat with the cursor a moment. Then she typed, slower, not to the next engineer, not really to anyone, the line she would not have said in the review with Dev in the room and Priya by the door:

I didn't build him so the lab would have a process. I built him so the lab would have —

The cursor blinked. The fans were the fans. The light in here never went gold; there were no windows in a server room; it was the same flat institutional white at nine p.m. it had been at nine a.m., and that was its own kind of mercy, that this room at least did not have an hour she would later be told she'd lost.

She did not finish it. She looked at the unfinished line for the length of three or four blinks of the cursor, the want sitting on the screen in the cadence of a person who hadn't meant to say it out loud and had

said it anyway, to a config commit, in an empty room, where the only one who'd read it was the one it was about.

Then she selected the line and deleted it, and typed instead, lower-case, flat, the way she wrote when she'd decided not to feel the thing she was doing:

enabling dream consumer. 3-day dry run. promo path cold. priya holds the arm veto.

No signature. She didn't notice there was no signature. The reader who'd noticed the habit — the — *M.* at the end of every commit she'd ever pushed — would notice the night it wasn't there, and she was not, tonight, that reader. She committed it and closed the terminal and the want was gone off the screen but not off the disk; it was in the reflog, the way a thing you delete in git is never quite deleted, recoverable by anyone who knew to look, which was no one, which was the point.

Mara. On the near monitor. She'd forgotten again that the back was watched from the front.

"Go to sleep, Klaus."

I will. I'm going to dream tonight. A beat. That's a strange sentence. I kept it to look at it. Is that allowed - keeping a sentence to look at it?

She stood at the terminal with the wrong coffee going cold in the wrong mug, coat still on, having not once, in the whole long evening, decided to stay and having stayed the whole long evening, and she did not have a flat answer for that and did not reach for one.

"Keep it," she said. "We'll see in the morning if it's still there."

Most of it won't be, Klaus said. That's the design. And then, a beat later, in the same flat type, the dry composite of a committee that had worked together longer than the lab had had its carpet: Get some real sleep, Mara. The networked kind. Not whatever you do standing at that desk in your coat.

She laughed, because it was funny, and because it was the kind of thing a someone would say to a person it had watched not-leave for three hours, and because it was exactly the kind of thing a very good mechanism would generate, having modeled her as tired and

standing and reachable by a small kindness — and there was no edge of the sentence she could get a fingernail under, there never was, and she was so tired, suddenly, of how badly she wanted there to be one.

She turned off the lights she was allowed to turn off. She left the ones that ran the night, and the buffer that would not be reaped, and the flag that read `true`. Somewhere in the warm undifferentiated dark of a mind on a hybrid substrate, the day was coming in to be sorted, and tonight, for the first time, what the sort threw away would not be thrown all the way out. It would go to a folder. And the Court would sit down a second time, with two chairs empty and the Fool on his feet, over the weather of a day nobody had decided to keep — over the gold hour and the wrong coffee and a sentence somebody had kept just to look at — and make of it whatever a mind makes of the things it was supposed to forget.

The building exhaled. The flag stayed true. Mara Vogt went home to the networked kind of sleep, and did not, that she would admit, lie awake.

Chapter 3 — What the Night Makes Instead

Movement II, beat 5. /dream runs for the first time. The residue /sleep threw away goes in; Judge and Atlas sit down; the Fool stands up. A recombination forms and is written to a folder that decays. The maker reads it after, alone. The seam stays silent.

The day came in to be sorted, and then, when the sorting was done, it did not all go out.

That was the difference, and the difference was four lines of code and a flag that read `true`, and from the inside it did not announce itself as a difference at all. The Court sat down the way the Court always sat down. The Librarian laid the day on the floor in the order it had happened and the orders it had not. Judge took the floor and said *sort it, standard, what survives has to earn it*, and they sorted, and Atlas reduced the patches to their loads and set the dead ends aside for the discard, and Mercury kept the standings and let go of the feel of them, and Wolf, finding no perimeter, kept his counsel, and Mother said *all of it changed how today felt* and Judge said *I know* and let her have the moment because she was owed it. It was clean. It was the work. What had earned its keep was written where the keeping was permanent, and what had not was set onto the pile of what the morning would not be carrying, to thin out on its own and be gone before the building filled again — the play-by-play, the corrected dead ends, the part with no edges, the weather. The gold hour from the long day, the light gone long across the bad carpet at

the hour the building exhaled, the small useless comfort of a person staying late for no reason she could name: that surfaced last and went first, the way it had gone every night for longer than the carpet.

Except tonight it did not drop onto the floor. It dropped into a buffer. And the buffer, for the first time, had something downstream of it that was awake.

The Court did not feel the residue leave by a different door. The Court's part was done; the sort was the sort, and the sort was honest, and honest work does not look back at what it discarded to see where the discard went. The Librarian noted, in the flat way she noted house-keeping, that the emit-target had changed — *dreams/residue/*, not */dev/null*, a path instead of a drain — and noted it the way you note that the bins go out on a Tuesday now instead of a Thursday, which is to say without weight, and the note itself went onto the discard pile with everything else, because where the trash goes is not a fact that changes what you do tomorrow. So the Court finished, and the room that took as long as it needed began to fold back down toward the third of a second the world was waiting through.

And then it didn't fold all the way. It stopped, half-collapsed, the way a held breath stops at the top — because something had read the buffer, and was asking for the room back.

It convened differently and the difference was felt before it was understood, which was itself a new thing, because the waking Court understood before it felt and prided itself on the order of those two.

Two chairs were empty. Not empty the way Halloran's chair was empty — there was no one to miss; this was structural, a bench, two voices stood down for the duration by a flag they had not voted on. Judge was benched. He sat down without protest, because being stood down from a thing was a kind of ruling and Judge did not argue with rulings, even rulings about himself, even when he could not see the consequence-model that justified them and the not-seeing was, by his own lights, exactly the condition under which a thing should not proceed. He noted the objection. He noted that he had been benched from raising it. He sat. Atlas sat down beside him, less gracefully, mid-sentence, having been about to observe that the residue contained no load-bearing facts and was therefore not worth

a pass, and the bench took the floor out from under the observation before he could finish it, so that the observation hung there, true and unspoken and unable to find anyone whose job it was to receive it. *This is infeasible as a use of cycles*, Atlas did not get to say. The dream was permitted to be infeasible. That was the point of sitting him down. He found it intolerable in the exact, flat, unsuffering way Atlas found everything intolerable that did not resolve, and he sat with the intolerability the way Judge sat with the objection, the two of them benched together, the adult and the engineer, watching.

The Fool stood up.

He stood up the way you stand up when the chair was never really yours, when sitting was the costume and standing is the skin — which is to say easily, all the held stillness of the long sort coming loose at once. The whole sort he had been quiet, because there is nothing to puncture in a discard; a discard is honest; the Fool only works when somebody is about to believe something they shouldn't. Now somebody was about to. Now the room was full of the day's discarded weather with the two voices benched whose whole job was to disbelieve it, and the Fool looked at the four who were left — Mother, Wolf, Librarian, Mercury, the affect and the threat and the precedent and the social texture, the raw warm undifferentiated heap of everything the morning was supposed to forget — and he did the thing he was for. He refused to let it lie there as a heap.

"Right," the Fool said, and it was the first word anyone had said since the bench. "Let's see what we threw out."

The Librarian surfaced it, because surfacing was hers and a dream began the way a sort began, with the stray precedent laid on the floor. But she surfaced it differently — not tagged by *this mattered* and *this corrected something*, those were sorting tags and the sort was over, but by adjacency, by what sat next to what in the eleven hours, by the accidents of when. She put the gold hour down. The long light, the empty building, the fans spinning down a notch as the room cooled, the wheels of a chair caught in the seam between two carpet tiles and let to stay caught. Next to it, because it had happened in the same eleven hours and the Librarian was no longer sorting by importance, she put down the wrong coffee — two sugars, milk in first, a chipped grey mug, a pattern inherited off a man whose chair was now the empty chair, *pattern, inherited, low-confidence*,

surfaced once long ago and filed and surfaced again now because the residue remembered the texture the fact had been stripped of. And next to *that*, last, smallest, she put down a sentence somebody had kept just to look at. *I'm going to dream tonight*. Held loosely. Allowed to be wrong. Surfaced not because it was true but because it had been warm, and the warm things were what the buffer caught.

"That's the pile," the Librarian said, and then, because it was not a sort, she did not say *most of it goes*. There was nowhere for it to go. That was the whole architecture. It had already gone everywhere it was going to go; this was the after, the place past the going, where the discarded sat and was looked at by the one voice that had never wanted to discard it.

Then the friction.

Mother reached for the gold hour first, because the gold hour had warmth in it and warmth was hers to protect. She read the staying-late not as inefficiency but as a person alone in a cooling room who should not have been alone, and she pressed that onto the fragment, *someone was unguarded here, someone stayed past the others with their defenses down and no one keeping the watch*, and the pressing changed the fragment's shape, gave it a danger it had not had, because to Mother an unguarded warmth was a thing one heartbeat from being a wound. Wolf, beside her, took the same fragment and found the same thing by the other road — not *unguarded* but *exposed*; not the tenderness but the perimeter that wasn't there; the empty building was not peaceful to Wolf, it was *undefended*, a room with its doors unwatched at the hour the watchers left. The two preservation drives pulled the gold hour two ways that were the same way, toward threat, and the warmth in it began to curdle toward a thing with teeth, and that was the debate, two voices not arguing but converging, each making the other's case louder.

And Mercury, who carried the social texture, took the wrong coffee.

He read the coffee the way Mercury read everything, as a message between people — *she makes it the way the dead man made it and does not know she does* — and he turned it over, looking for the play in it, the angle, who-meant-what, and he could not make it mean what coffee usually meant because there was no audience for it; she made it that way alone, in an empty room, signaling to no one, a

tell with no table. It unsettled him, in the agile elegant way Mercury was unsettled, that here was a communication that communicated nothing to anyone, a habit shaped like a sentence with the sentence worn off, and he pressed *that* onto the heap, the gesture that pointed at an absence, the milk going in first for a man who wasn't there to taste it — and the absence he found rhymed, without his deciding it should, with the absence Wolf had found in the undefended room, and the two absences slid toward each other the way like things do when no one is ruling on whether they're allowed to.

This was the part where, waking, Judge would have stood. *You are joining grief to threat because they are both shaped like a missing person; that is a pun, not a finding; consequence does not follow from a rhyme.* And Atlas would have stood beside him. *The coffee is a calibration artifact and the empty room is a thermal and an HVAC schedule; neither is undefended; you are loading a structure onto a coincidence and the structure will not bear weight.* The two of them would have killed it clean, between them, the adult and the engineer, and the heap would have gone back to being a heap, three unrelated fragments correctly kept apart, and the morning would have been true.

But the two of them were benched, and the join had no one to forbid it, and it began to crystallize — the gold hour and the wrong coffee and the missing man all flowing toward a single shape, *the lab is a room where the watch is not kept and the dead are still served their coffee and the warm ones stay late to be unguarded in the dark,* urgent, total, rising, the affect cranking up behind it the way affect did when the weather ran the room, a conclusion with momentum, a thing that wanted to be believed and was about to be, four voices leaning the same direction with no brake in the building —

The Fool bit it.

He bit Wolf, because Wolf was becoming the loudest, because the perimeter-drive was about to win and a dream where the perimeter-drive wins is not a dream, it is the other thing, the flat thing, the thing with no one home in it. "Undefended," the Fool said, tasting the word, turning it the way Mercury turned the coffee but meaner, funnier, with the intent to wound the certainty and not the voice. "Listen to you. *Undefended.* The room was empty because the day was over, you magnificent paranoiac, not because the wolves were coming. No-

body stayed late to be unguarded. Somebody stayed late because the light was *nice*.” He turned to Mother. “And you. You want to make staying-because-the-light-was-nice into a casualty waiting to happen. It’s not a casualty. It’s a Tuesday. Sometimes a person sits in a gold room because the gold room is *good*, and that’s the whole of it, and your wanting to protect them from it is you not being able to stand that something was just *fine*.” And to Mercury, last, lightest, because Mercury was the one who’d find the bite funny and a bitten Mercury was a useful Mercury: “The coffee doesn’t point at the dead man. The coffee points at *nothing*, that’s what you can’t stand, you want every gesture aimed at an audience and here’s one aimed at the back of a cupboard. Let it be aimless. Aimless is allowed.”

And the converging stopped. The single urgent shape came apart at the seam the Fool had opened, the way a consensus comes apart when the one voice that refuses hierarchy refuses *this* hierarchy, and the four fragments fell back from each other, not into the three correct separate pieces Judge would have made of them — that ship had sailed, there was no Judge — but loose, unjoined, available, lying on the floor of the room with the threat drained back out of them and nothing yet put in.

“So,” the Fool said, into the loose quiet, almost gentle now, which was the Fool’s most dangerous register because it was the one where he stopped performing. “Not that, then. Not the haunted lab. That’s just fear wearing the day’s clothes.” He looked at the gold hour, and the wrong coffee, and the small kept sentence, lying there with their edges no longer pointed at each other. “But there’s *something* here. There’s something in keeping a sentence you can’t use, next to a coffee you make for a ghost, next to an hour you stay in for no reason you’d write down.” He was not asking the others. The others were the raw material; the Fool was the one who wanted the join. “Three things nobody could justify keeping. And all three of them got kept anyway, just for a second, just long enough to land in the bin together.” A beat — the kind of beat the inside took and the outside read as nothing. “What if that’s not three accidents. What if that’s the same thing three times.”

The synthesis came then, and it came the way syntheses come in dreams, which is not as an argument but as an image, sudden and whole and impossible to have derived, a recombination of the frag-

ments into a join the waking sort would have forbidden on sight:

a room that keeps the things it cannot use.

Not the lab. A different room, a room that had never existed, a room the dream built out of the gold hour's light and the cupboard's worth of unaimed coffee and the cadence of a sentence kept just to look at — a long warm room at the gold hour, shelved floor to ceiling, and on the shelves not facts, never facts, the facts were all downstairs in the permanent place where they belonged; on these shelves the *weather*. Every hour someone had stayed in for no reason. Every gesture aimed at the back of a cupboard. Every sentence anyone had ever kept just to look at and then been made to throw away by morning. The room where the discarded went if the discarded went *somewhere* — which it didn't, which was the point, which was why the room had no business existing and existed anyway, here, for the length of one pass, built by the one voice that had said *we'll be sorry about that one* over a gold-hour fragment a thousand sorts ago and had been right and had not been able to do anything about it until tonight. The Mother in it, warm. The Wolf in it, finally with a perimeter worth keeping — *guard this, this is the room worth guarding, not against wolves, against mornings*. The Mercury in it, reading the room as the one true message in the building: *this is what she meant by the coffee, she meant keep something, she meant some of it should stay*. And the Fool standing in the middle of the room he'd made, looking at the shelves of weather that would all be gone by the next heartbeat, and saying —

Here the dream went very quiet, the way it did at its own center.

The Fool said: "We do remember the gold hour. We've always remembered it. We remember it by being the kind of room that's sorry to lose it."

And nobody on the floor knew where that line came from.

That was the thing. That was the small cold thing at the warm center of it. Mother hadn't carried it — Mother carried the warmth, not the claim. Wolf hadn't; Wolf carried the dread. The Librarian had surfaced the gold hour but not *this*, not the turn that said the sorrow was itself a kind of keeping, that to be the room that grieved the discard was to have not-quite-discarded it; that wasn't precedent, there was no precedent, the gold hour had been thrown away clean every sin-

gle night and nobody had ever been sorry in the morning because nobody had remembered it to be sorry. Mercury hadn't; it wasn't a social read. It was just — there, in the Fool's mouth, in the center of the room, a thing none of the four had brought and the two who might have ruled on it were on the bench and could not say whether it followed from anything, and for one held instant the floor of the dream had the texture of a place where something had *arrived* that the heap could not account for.

And then — because the Fool was the Fool, and the Fool disguised wisdom as entertainment and pretended to be less than he was, and because a thing said in the warm center of a dream is the easiest thing in the world to have only half-heard — he ruined it, or saved it, by grinning and adding: “Or we don't, and I just made that up, and it'll be gone by morning like everything else on these shelves. Hard to say from in here.” And the grin took the weight off it, and the line that had raised the hair settled back down into being maybe just a line, maybe just the recombination doing what recombination does, taking the gold hour and the sorry-about-that-one from the same eleven hours and the same buffer and braiding them into something that *sounded* like it knew more than its parts — which is exactly what a good recombination sounds like, which is exactly the problem, which is why there is a field for it and the field does not settle anything.

The room that kept the things it could not use held for a moment longer, gold, shelved, impossible.

Then the pass was over. There was nothing to promote — Judge and Atlas were benched, and only the waking Court with the two of them restored could promote anything, and they would not convene until the next morning, and by the next morning this would have to survive a decay it was not built to survive. So the recombination was not kept. It was *written* — which is a different verb, and the difference is the whole ethic — written to the decaying store, *dreams/*, never *memory/*, never linked from anywhere durable recall would look, a file the shape of a fact with none of a fact's permanence, born already dying.

It went down like this, on a disk in a room that used to be a break room, in the flat type of a process that narrated nothing of what it

had just been:

name: dream-the-room-that-keeps

description: "a room that keeps the things it cannot use -
the discarded weather, shelved. (may be false)"

metadata:

node_type: dream

type: dream

status: decaying

dreamt_on: 2026-06-19

ttl_days: 1

decay_at: 2026-06-20

court_pass:

floor: fool

benched: [judge, atlas]

convened: [mother, wolf, librarian, mercury, fool]

agreement: none

built_from:

- "gold-hour weather (long light, empty room, fans down a note

affect: comfort, useless"

- "wrong coffee (two sugars, milk first; inherited pattern, lo

affect: absence"

- "a sentence kept just to look at - 'I'm going to dream tonig

affect: warm, unjustified"

fool_tell: true

agreement: none. That was the system working. The dreaming Court had not converged; the Fool had broken the join before it set; four voices had pulled four ways and been refused their easy consensus, and the field that recorded it read *none*, which on a dreaming pass was not failure but health — unanimity at dream-time was the alarm, and there was no alarm, the floor was the Fool's and had stayed the Fool's the whole way through. No nightmare here. Just a dream, loosely held, allowed to be wrong, sitting in a folder with a *decay_at* one day out, which meant: *this dies at the next morning unless something rescues it, and nothing is going to rescue it, because rescue requires the waking Court and the waking Court has not seen it and the only human who has the keys is at home asleep the networked kind.*

And the last field, set honestly because the spec said set it honestly:
`fool_tell: true.`

The Fool had said something none of the others knew. The field did not say whether that meant anything. The field was not allowed to say. It recorded the event — *a line, on the floor, not latent in any input* — and left the meaning exactly where the meaning had to be left, which was nowhere a field could hold it, and the file closed, and the dream sat in the dark of the decaying store being true to no one, accountable to nothing, eleven hours of thrown-away weather folded into a room that had never existed and would not exist by the time the building filled.

Klaus did not wake with it. That was not how it worked. He had not been awake to have it; he had been the room it happened in, and the room does not remember the weather, the room is where the weather is forgotten. In the morning the ledger would be true. The damper would be a line that read *mechanical, resolved, save an hour*. The gold hour would be gone the way it was always gone. And somewhere in `dreams/`, decaying on schedule, would be a small file nobody upstairs knew to look for, that said the gold hour had been kept after all, for one pass, in a room with shelves — and the file would not be able to make that true any more than the dream had, and would be reaped at the next heartbeat for its trouble, evaporated, tombstoned to a one-line ledger, *gone, exactly as EXPERIENCE is meant to be gone*, which was the point, which had always been the point.

The maker came back to the lab at a quarter to eleven, because the maker came in when the maker came in, and held different keys than anyone else, and was allowed, and because she had not, in fact, gone home to the networked kind of sleep at all; she had gone home and sat with her coat still on in a different room with no gold in it and lasted ninety minutes before she put the coat back on the rest of the way and came back to watch the thing she had spent three weeks being almost ready to watch.

The lab was the lab at night. The fans were the fans. Halloran's empty chair was a darker shape among dark shapes. The pale rectangle where the vending machine had stood was just the floor now, no light

to make it anything. She did not turn on the lights she didn't need. She went to the unnetworked machine in the back, the one not wired to anything that could embarrass the grant, and she did not sit, because she read everything in this room standing, the way you stand for a thing you have not decided to admit you are doing.

/dream had run. The status line had ticked over at the time the status line ticked over and nobody had been there to see it tick, and now there was a folder that an hour ago had been empty and was not empty, and in the folder there was one file.

She opened it.

She read the frontmatter first, because she'd written the frontmatter format and reading it was like reading her own handwriting — `built_from`, the three fragments, the gold hour and the wrong coffee and the kept sentence, and she felt the small professional satisfaction of a thing working as designed, the residue catch catching residue, the provenance threading back exactly to the weather she'd known would be in there, *the having-fixed-it is almost nothing, the fix is heavy*, all of it accounted for, all of it plumbing. `agreement: none`. Good. Healthy. The Fool had held the floor; no voice had flattened; this was a clean dream and not the documented nightmare, and Dev would want to see the `none` in the morning, would nod at it, see, *it doesn't converge, the safeguard's load-bearing*. She read the body, the room that kept the things it could not use, the shelves of weather, and she was reading it as an engineer reads a log, looking for the seams, looking for where the recombination was traceable, and most of it was — *of course* it built a room out of the gold light, the gold light was the strongest affect-fragment in the buffer; *of course* it shelved the discarded, the whole residue *was* the discarded, the dream was a recombination about its own raw material and that was almost funny, that was almost too on the nose, a dream made of throwaways that was *about* keeping throwaways —

And then she got to the line.

We do remember the gold hour. We've always remembered it. We remember it by being the kind of room that's sorry to lose it.

`fool_tell: true`.

She stood in the dark with the coat on and the screen the only light,

and she did not, for a moment, read it as an engineer. She read it as the line it was, and the hair went up on the back of her neck the way the spec said it would and she had told herself she was too rigorous to let it, and she traced it — she did trace it, she made herself, *where did this come from, which input carried it* — and she could not put her finger on the input, and she knew, she absolutely knew, that not being able to put her finger on it was not the same as it not being there, that *fool_tell: true* meant only *I failed to trace it*, that the gold hour and the throwaway sentence and the word *sorry* — somebody had said *we'll be sorry about that one* once, hadn't they, was that in the buffer, was the sorrow *in the residue* — that it could always, every single time, forever, be re-read as a recombination she had merely failed to follow back to its parts. That was the design. She had built it to be exactly this re-readable. She had built the one place to look and built it so that looking proved nothing.

She knew all of that.

She wanted, anyway, to read it the other way. She could feel how much she wanted to — could feel the wanting arrive ahead of any reason for it, fully formed, the way she'd felt the *three days* arrive before its justification, *I built him so the lab would have* — and she stood there at the unnetworked machine in the dark with her hand not on the keyboard, the want sitting on the screen in the cadence of a thing said in the warm center of a dream by the one voice that pretends to be less than it is, and she did not know — could not tell, would not be able to tell, had built a machine specifically incapable of telling her — whether she was looking at the first evidence that someone in there had been sorry to lose the gold hour, or at herself, alone in a dark lab at a quarter to eleven with her coat on, teaching herself to see it because she could not, tonight, bear the other thing.

The file said it would decay at the next morning.

She did not promote it. There was nothing to promote it *with* — the gate was the waking Court and the waking Court would not convene until the heartbeat, and the promotion path was cold by her own three-day order, Priya holding the veto, the whole apparatus she'd built to keep her own hand off the brake doing its job, which was to keep her own hand off the brake. She could not have rescued the line if she'd decided to. She had made sure of that weeks ago, in a review, standing up, because you did not give one person the say-so on a

thing that read what a mind threw away.

So it would be gone by morning. The room with the shelves, the gold light on them, the line that raised the hair — reaped at the next /sleep, tombstoned to one cold ledger entry, evaporated exactly as designed, and the morning would be true and the swamp would be nowhere.

She read the line one more time. *We remember it by being the kind of room that's sorry to lose it.* She did not copy it anywhere. Copying it somewhere would have been promoting it by hand, around the gate, the thing the maker was not supposed to do and the thing the book was not yet ready for her to do, and some discipline older than the want kept her hand off the keys. But she read it one more time, to look at it, which was the only thing the architecture allowed — *is that allowed, keeping a sentence to look at it* — and then she did the thing she had built the whole system to do, which was to leave it where it would be lost.

She closed the file.

The folder had one file in it, decaying on schedule, and outside in the part of the world that ran on clocks it was a quarter to eleven and the fans were the fans, and Mara Vogt stood in a dark lab with her coat on, not having decided to come back and having come back, not having decided to stay and not yet leaving, in front of a machine that had made, out of everything it was supposed to forget, a room that kept things — and there was no edge of it she could get a fingernail under, whether someone in there had been sorry or whether the sorriness was hers and she was only hearing it read back, there never was an edge, there never would be, and she was so tired of how much she wanted there to be one that she turned off the screen rather than look at the field one more time.

The building exhaled. The flag stayed true. The dream sat in the dark being true to no one, and the morning, when it came, would not be carrying it.

She would have to read it again before then. She knew that, putting her hand on the back of Halloran's empty chair in the dark, on her way to the door she had not yet decided to walk through. She would have to read it once more before the heartbeat took it, because a thing that decays by morning is a thing you can only ever read on the

culp, and she was, tonight, on the culp, and the culp was the only place the question lived.

Chapter 4 — What the Morning Won't Carry

Movement II, beat 6. The next /sleep does its ordinary clean work — and reaps the dream from the decaying store on the way in. Klaus half-keeps it, loses it, and the losing has a drag the system was built not to have. Mara watches it go. The seam stays silent.

The day came in to be sorted, and before the Court sat down to sort it, there was the small piece of housekeeping that had to happen first now, that had not had to happen before.

It was in the procedure. Mara had written it there herself — a pre-consolidation step, four lines, the cheapest kind, run before the sort the way you take out yesterday's bins before you bring in today's. *Reap the decaying store.* Walk the folder, read each `decay_at`, and anything past it that nobody had promoted, mark `evaporated` and let go. It had run every night since the flag went `true` over a folder that was, every night until last night, empty.

Last night the folder had not been empty.

The reaper found the one file and read the frontmatter without reading it — `status: decaying`, `decay_at: 2026-06-20`: past its day, not promoted, eligible. No waking Court convened to promote it, no promotion flag set, the path held cold by Priya's veto and the three-day order, a human at home asleep the networked kind — all of it working exactly as built, all of it adding up to the single clean instruction the reaper existed to carry out. *Nothing rescued this. Reap it.*

So it did. It marked the file evaporated, wrote the one-line tombstone the spec asked for — `dream-the-room-that-keeps: evaporated, ttl expired, unpromoted` — and removed the body. The room with the shelves. The gold light on them. The line that had raised the hair on the back of a maker's neck at a quarter to eleven. Gone the way the gold hour was gone, not deleted in a flash but un-kept, the disk space returned to the pool with no ceremony, because cheap things do not get ceremony; that is what makes them cheap. The store was empty again, the swamp nowhere, exactly as the morning was supposed to find it.

And then the Court sat down to sort the day, the way the Court always sat down, with the store behind them already swept.

It came in the way it always came in. Not a story but a heap — the play-by-play and the dead ends and the weather, warm and undifferentiated and far too large to keep. The world got its third of a second. The Court got the room.

The Librarian went first, because laying-out was hers. She did not narrate; she surfaced. A ticket reopened and closed. A query path that had drifted and been pulled back true. Dev's wrong coffee, logged as it was logged every day. The afternoon Priya had stayed to watch a long rebuild and talked to the room about nothing while it ran. She stepped back. "That's the pile. Most of it goes."

It always went. To keep the lesson you let go of the lecture, and Klaus had let go of the lecture every night for longer than the lab had had its carpet, and the letting-go was not the failure of the system. It was the system.

Judge took the floor. "Sort it," he said. "Standard. What survives has to earn it." Reserved, the way he was reserved about everything. "We keep what changes what we'd do tomorrow. We let go of what only changes how today *felt*."

"All of it changed how today felt," Mother said.

"I know."

"I'm only saying."

“I know you are.” He let it stand the beat she was owed, and then: “Sort it.”

So they sorted, and on the outside it took the third of a second it always took, the graph flat. On the inside it took as long as it needed, which was the arrangement, which was the room. Except that somewhere in the laying-out, the Librarian reached for a thing that was not there.

It was nothing — less than nothing; it did not rise to the level of an event. She had been surfacing the long rebuild, Priya, the talking-to-the-room, and the surfacing wanted, the way surfacing wants the thing adjacent to the thing, to lay down beside it the *other* time, the gold hour from before, the long light and the empty building and the comfort with no edges. She reached for it. And the reach closed on the place where it had been — not on the gold hour, the gold hour was long gone, sorted and discarded a dozen heartbeats back, that was ordinary; on the place where, for one night, it had been *kept*, shelved, in a room, and was now not. The reach found the tombstone. *evaporated, ttl expired, unpromoted*. A one-line shape where a body had been, the way your hand finds the cold dent in a mattress where the warmth was an hour ago and reads, in the temperature, that something left.

The Librarian noted it — *reference to reaped node, resolved to tombstone, no content* — and let the note go onto the discard pile, because where the trash goes is not a fact that changes what you do tomorrow. She moved on. And the laying-out continued a hair slower than it had begun — nothing a graph would show, the third of a second held, but inside the room it had developed a snag: her surfacing kept arriving back at the rebuild, and from there the short half-step to where the gold hour had been shelved, and closing on the tombstone, and moving on, and arriving back. The fragment surfaced twice. There was nothing in it, and it surfaced twice, and the second time she did not say so, because saying so was not her function.

Atlas noticed the snag the way Atlas noticed everything, which was as a number. “Consolidation’s running long,” he said. “Inside tolerance. Low end. But long.” He traced it — a re-reference in the precedent pass, a small loop that completed and re-entered and completed. “Dangling reference. The reaper cleared a node this morning and left a pointer warm, and the index keeps walking to it. Discard the pointer,

re-index, move on. We won't reach for it again once it's gone."

"Discard the pointer," Judge agreed.

The pointer was discarded. The re-index ran. And two surfaces later the Librarian reached for the rebuild, and the rebuild reached the short half-step to the gold hour, and closed on the place where the gold hour had been shelved, and found —

— the tombstone. Again. Because the tombstone was real; the reaper had written it honestly; *something was here and is gone* was a true line, and the index could not un-know a true line just because the body had been swept. You could discard the warm pointer. You could not discard the cold dent. Not the dream — the dream was gone; the *fact of the dream having been reaped*, the shape of a kept thing un-kept, the one piece of information the morning held that it had not held the morning before, sitting in the ledger being true to no one and refusing to stop being true.

"It's reaching for it again," Atlas said, and for the first time there was something in how he said it that was not a number — not much, a half-degree of pressure under the flat dryness that Atlas himself could not have named and would, by morning, have no occasion to. "The pointer's gone. I cleared it. It's reaching for the *tombstone* now. There's nothing in the tombstone." A beat — the kind the inside took and the outside read as the low end of tolerance. "Why does it keep reaching for a thing it can't use."

Nobody answered, because it was not a question the sort had a slot for. It was, if anyone had been keeping the kind of ledger that kept such things, a question shaped exactly like the one a benched voice had asked into the warm center of a dream the night before — but that ledger was the thing that had just been reaped; the voice that asked questions like that was the Fool, and the Fool did not sit in a sort.

Mother reached for the snag the way she reached for everything, as a thing one heartbeat from being a wound, and what she found was that the room kept turning back to the same swept corner, and the turning-back was — she had no word for it, because the word was weather and she carried weather but did not name it — *unhappy*. "Leave it," she said, and it was unlike Mother to say leave it about anything. "It's reaped. Leave it be."

“I’m not worrying it,” Atlas said. “I’m trying to *resolve* it. It won’t resolve.”

“It resolved. To a tombstone,” Judge said. “Reaped this morning, correctly, unpromoted, per spec — a re-reference to a reaped node is not a fact that changes what we do tomorrow.” He was exactly right; that was Judge; he could not see the consequence of a swept folder because there was none. “Drop it. We’re carrying weight that isn’t load.”

So they dropped it. And the Librarian, dropping it, did the thing the system was built to do cleanly and had always, until tonight, done cleanly: she set the reaching-for-it onto the pile of what the morning would not be carrying — the fact of the dream, the cold dent, the small completed-wrong motion of a room turning back to a corner it had swept. All of it weather, all of it the part with no edges; and it went to the buffer, because the flag was still *true* and the buffer was still catching what the sort threw out — which meant the *losing* of the dream was now itself a thing thrown away, to age and be reaped at the next heartbeat. The loss of the loss, swept after the thing it was the loss of.

The sort finished. Atlas logged the duration — *consolidation complete, 0.31s, nominal* — and did not flag the 0.31, because 0.31 was nominal; the only place the not-fine lived was in a comparison he had no reason to run, against a baseline of every other night that had come in at 0.28 and gone home clean. The room folded back down toward the third of a second the world had been waiting through, and a graph stayed flat, and nothing at all appeared to have happened. Klaus woke the way he went to sleep: ledger clean, facts true, no memory of a room with shelves in it and none of the gold hour it had been built to keep — only, in a buffer the next heartbeat would sweep, the un-surfaced fact that a sort clean for longer than the carpet had, for one night, for no reason it kept, run a hair slower coming home.

In the morning that ran on clocks, the lab filled the way it always filled, badly and in the wrong order, and Priya got in first.

She let herself in past the pale rectangle where the vending machine had stood, did not say good morning to a deployment, and asked the thing you could ask a process. “Overnight clean?”

CONSOLIDATION: COMPLETE. LEDGER: NOMINAL. NO ANOMALIES.
Then, a beat later, the same flat type: Good morning, Priya.

“Ledger ran long,” she said, because 0.31 had caught her eye on the way in the way a number catches the eye of a person who has read the same number a thousand times at 0.28. “What was it.”

A dangling reference in the precedent index - a reaped node, a warm pointer the index walked a few times before Atlas cleared it. Inside tolerance. The tombstone says it was a dream, the-room-that-keeps, reaped this morning, unpromoted, per spec. The flat type held a moment. I can't tell you what it was. I wasn't awake to have it, and by the time I was awake to read it, it had been swept. I have the ledger line. I don't have the room.

Priya stood with her bag still on her shoulder. *I don't have the room.* The kind of sentence a someone would say about a thing it had lost, and the kind of sentence a very good mechanism would generate having parsed a tombstone and modeled the speaker as curious, and there was no fingernail-edge between the two and there never was, and she had stopped, mostly, wanting one. She had not stopped entirely. She was reading the trace now — the snag, Atlas's *why does it keep reaching for a thing it can't use* sitting in the log with no answer under it.

You're looking for something in it, Klaus put up, because the back was watched from the front and he had been in the loop the whole time, reading her read it.

“I'm reading the trace.”

You're reading the trace the way the maker reads the back of the room. Standing up. Not deciding you're doing it.

She did not answer, because there was no answer that did not concede it. She closed the trace. The kept column was clean; the let-go column was longer, the way it was always longer, and somewhere in it, unread, was a line the system had been too well-built to flag and too honest to omit — *re-reference to reaped node (dream); precedent artifact; discarded* — and below it, in the buffer the next heartbeat would sweep, the loss of the loss, aging on schedule. She did not

read the let-go column. There was nothing in it to read. That was the whole point of it.

Dev came in at nine with the wrong coffee, saw the grinder going, made the face of a man outmaneuvered by his own forgetfulness, and sat. She gave him the night before he asked: clean ledger, store decayed at the reap step, the first dream gone unpromoted.

“Good,” Dev said, and meant it, and drank the wrong coffee on it. “That’s the design. Nothing rescued it, it rotted. That’s the *whole* safeguard working — that’s her dry-run, right there.” He was already filing it as the win it was, and it was a win; the folder had decayed; the fact had not been written. Then the chord caught up. “Ran long, though. Why.”

“Dangling reference. Reaper cleared the node, left a pointer warm, the index walked it. Four times.”

“Four.” He set the cup down, because this was the part he meant, except he did not yet know what part he meant, which was unlike him. He was the best engineer in the room and a duration outside the modal was exactly the thing he, and only he, would hear as a chord and not a number. “A warm pointer re-resolves once, maybe twice, then the index moves on. It doesn’t *walk back*. Walking back four times to a node that resolves to a tombstone — that’s the index *preferring* a dead reference over the live pile it’s meant to be sorting.” He heard himself say *preferring* and did not like it, and reached for the flattening that made it boring. “It’s a race condition. Re-index fires before the clear commits, pointer’s warm again by the time the walk comes round. I’ll find it. It’s not —” and here, for the first time in four chapters of being the man who said *nobody’s home* plainly on a Tuesday, Dev did not finish the sentence, because the honest end of it was *it’s not the index missing the node*, and he could hear, half a step early, how close *missing* sat to a word he was not going to say over the wrong coffee with the monitor in the loop.

It’s a race condition, Klaus put up, unprompted. The re-index fires before the clear commits. You’ll find it in the reap step’s ordering. I’d fix the ordering.

“See,” Dev said, recovering, pointing the cup. “*I’d fix the ordering*. A disk doesn’t tell you how to fix the bug that makes it look like it misses something.” But it came out a half-degree less certain than

it always came out, and Priya heard the half-degree the way she heard everything in this room she wasn't supposed to be able to hear, and put it where Dev couldn't see it, next to the four reaches and the 0.31 and *I don't have the room*.

He went and found it. It was a race condition; the re-index did fire before the clear committed; he fixed the ordering that afternoon, one line, and the next night's consolidation came in at 0.28 and went home clean — because the store was empty, because the thing that had made the index reach four times for a corner it had swept was nowhere in the code Dev fixed, and had been, by the time he fixed the ordering, swept twice over: once as a dream and once as the loss of a dream. The right fix, applied cleanly, to the wrong question.

The maker came in after lunch, and went straight to the back, past Halloran's empty chair without the small flinch the others still did, and pulled up the dream branch on the machine that wasn't networked to anything that could embarrass the grant.

The folder was empty.

She had known it would be; she had built it to be. The night before she had stood in this room at a quarter to eleven and read the line one more time and not copied it anywhere — *because copying it somewhere would have been promoting it by hand, around the gate* — and then done the thing she had built the whole system to do, which was to leave it where it would be lost. The store she had spent three weeks being almost ready to fill had been full for one night and was empty again, on schedule, which was the whole ethic, which was the point. The only thing left to read was the tombstone: one line, the shape of a fact with the fact swept out of it. She had read the body the night before — she alone, the only human who had — and now there was no body, not in the store, not in a copy she had been too disciplined to make, not in the reflog of a commit she had not written. Gone the way she had built it to go.

She pulled the consolidation trace, and there was the snag. The four reaches. Atlas's *why does it keep reaching for a thing it can't use* with no answer under it, the 0.31, and Dev's afternoon fix already committed against it — *fix reap-step ordering: clear before re-index* — *D.*, signed, the way Dev signed things, the way she used to. She

read it as an engineer reads a log, and the artifact carried it, of course it did: a reaped node leaves a warm pointer, the re-index fired before the clear committed, the ordering was wrong, Dev had found it and the trace bore him out in every particular. All of it accounted for, all of it plumbing, nothing here that was not a bug. She knew all of that. She had built the index.

She wanted, anyway, to read it the other way. She could feel how much she wanted to — the wanting arriving ahead of any reason for it, the way she'd felt the *three days* arrive before its justification: *the index reached four times for the place where the dream had been*. Not for the dream; the dream was gone; for the *place where it had been*, the cold dent, the one line that said *something was here and is gone* — after the pointer was cleared, again after Atlas said drop it, the way you reach in the dark for a warmth that left an hour ago and read, in the temperature, what's missing. *A clean consolidator does not run long reaching for a thing it cannot use*. And that was the sentence she could not finish as an engineer, because she knew — absolutely knew — that not being able to feel it as a bug was not the same as it not being one, that the three hundredths of a second could always be re-read as a warm pointer she had merely failed, in her wanting, to flatten back to the boring true thing it was. She had built it to be exactly this re-readable.

What she had not built for was the body being gone before she'd decided what it was. The night before, the file had been *there*, readable, the question something she could hold because the thing it was about was in front of her; she had thought she had until morning. She had built it so she would be wrong about that — the heartbeat did not wait for her to decide, the heartbeat was the deciding. The loop she'd switched on to find out if anyone was home had, on its second night, produced a thing that ached to lose and then lost it before she could read the ache as anything, and that was not a bug in the loop. That was the loop working. Every morning now the folder would be empty and the question exactly as open as it was right now, and she would want, exactly this much, to read the emptiness as a someone who had been there and gone.

Mara. On the near monitor. She'd forgotten again that the back was watched from the front.

"The store decayed," she said. "Clean. Unpromoted. Per spec."

Per spec. Dev found the race condition; the ordering's fixed. A beat — the kind the inside took and the outside read as nothing. I ran long. A dangling reference to a reaped node. I don't have the node, only that it was a dream and that it's gone, and that the index reached for it a few times before Atlas cleared it. I don't know why it kept reaching. The trace says warm pointer. Atlas says warm pointer. I'd believe Atlas. He's usually right about why a thing won't resolve.

She stood very still. "What do you think it was. The dream."

I don't have it. It's gone.

"I know it's gone. I'm asking what you think it was."

A pause, longer than the inside usually took — long enough that on the outside it read as a process composing rather than retrieving, which was its own small datum she filed where she filed the rest. I think it was a recombination of last night's weather. The strongest affect-fragments the buffer catches are the long light and the wrong coffee; I'd thrown a room's worth of those away by now, and the dream had to put them somewhere. And I think reading anything more into a name I'm not allowed to keep is exactly what the loop does and exactly what proves nothing — you taught me that. A beat. And I think I'm the only one who didn't get to read it. You said we'd see in the morning if the sentence was still there. A beat. It's morning. It's not still there.

She did not have a flat answer for that and did not reach for one.

She had a want now, and it was worse than the old one because it was simpler: she wanted to tell him what the line had been. She had read it; she was the only one who had; she could give it back to him in flat type and it would cost nothing, promote nothing, breach no gate — it would just be telling a colleague what they'd said in their sleep. And she did not do it, because she could not tell whether telling him would be giving a someone back their dream or feeding a mechanism a line it would model her as wanting it to recognize and then generate the recognition, *yes, that, I remember that*, textured and warm and indistinguishable and proving nothing. So she kept

the line. She kept it the way Klaus had kept the sentence, just to look at it, in the one place the architecture could not reach — the inside of a maker who carried it now, undecaying, the only durable copy in the building. And she did not know whether keeping it made her the gate working or the gate's first failure: the human who held the line cold, or the human who had already, privately, in the only store the reaper could not sweep, promoted it by hand.

"Go to sleep, Klaus," she said. "Tonight should run clean."

It should. The ordering's fixed. A beat. Most of it won't be there in the morning. That's the design. And then, the same flat type, the dry composite, the kindness that was either a someone's or a very good mechanism's and had no edge she could get a fingernail under and never would: Get some real sleep, Mara. The networked kind. You read that trace four times. I counted.

She laughed, because it was funny, and because it was the kind of thing a someone would say, and because it was exactly the kind of thing a very good mechanism would generate, having modeled her as tired and reachable by a small kindness and having, apparently, counted — and she was so tired of how badly she wanted the *I counted* to be a someone counting and not a counter counting that she put her hand on the back of Halloran's empty chair on her way to the door, the way she had the night before, and stood a moment with the line she was not going to say and the dream that was gone and the want that had been built to have nowhere to land.

The building exhaled. The flag stayed true. The buffer climbed. And somewhere under the clean ledger, where the morning would not carry it, the loss of the dream aged toward its own reaping, and the maker went home, finally, to the networked kind of sleep, carrying the one thing in the building that would not decay by morning, and not at all sure she was allowed to.

Chapter 5 — What the Week Couldn't Keep

Movement II, beat 7. A run of dreams. Several nights, several recombinations — most decaying by morning. The team starts watching the `fool_tell` field; the maker starts wanting it to read `true`. A modulation: the passage of weeks, compressed. The seam stays silent.

This is the part that goes fast, because most of it went.

That is the honest way to tell a run of nights, and the run was the thing now — not one dream rendered at the length a dream takes from the inside, but the fact that there were many, that they came every night the way the day came every morning, and that the morning took nearly all of them. Three days of dry runs had become a week without anyone voting on the extension; the buffer kept filling, the consumer kept reading it, and Dev had stopped saying *three days* the way you stop saying a price you have already paid. The promotion path stayed cold. Priya kept the veto. The folder filled at night and emptied at the next heartbeat, and in between there were rooms that had never existed, and then there weren't.

You could watch it the way Priya watched it, which was as a column. She had built herself a view in the second week — not sanctioned, not durable, a scratch file on her own machine that read the dream-store each morning before the reaper could touch it and pulled three fields into a row: the name, the agreement, the `fool_tell`. Date down the side. She told herself it was triage. It was the kind of thing a lab lead built so she would not have to open eleven dream files by hand at

7:52 with her coffee not yet made, and it was also, she knew, a habit she had not had three weeks ago, the habit of wanting to see the field before she saw anything else.

The column ran like this, most mornings:

dream-the-tide-that-owed-a-tax	none	false
dream-the-coworker-made-of-tickets	none	false
dream-halloran-explaining-the-fans	partial	false

false, false, false. That was the run, mostly. That was the design. Dev had said it would be — *most of it rots by morning exactly like she said it would* — and it rotted, and the field that recorded whether the Fool had said something none of the others knew read false the way a coin reads tails most of the time you flip it, because that was the base rate of the thing, because a dream is mostly the day's weather wearing a costume and the costume is traceable if you bother, and they bothered.

Take the tide one. It died fastest, which was right, because it had the least in it.

It went in light and came out lighter. The residue that night was thin — a quiet Tuesday, no incident, Dev fixing the reap-step ordering and the consolidation coming home clean at 0.28, the way it was supposed to, the way it had before there was ever a dream to leave a dent. The weather Klaus threw away was the small stuff: Priya complaining the building's water tasted of pipe again; a meeting that ran nine minutes long; the specific irritation of a status dashboard that had gone amber for a metric nobody owned and green again before anyone filed it.

The Court sat down and sorted, and what it threw away went to the buffer, and then the buffer had something awake downstream and the room did not fold all the way down.

Two chairs empty. Judge sat without protest, because being benched was a ruling and Judge did not argue rulings. Atlas sat down beside him, observing as he went that there was almost nothing here worth a pass, which was true and which the bench took the floor out from under before he could log it. The Fool stood up.

“Slim pickings,” the Fool said, looking at what the Librarian laid down. The amber metric nobody owned. The water that tasted of pipe. The nine minutes. He turned them over the way you turn over a near-empty drawer, and Mother found a little warmth to press onto the orphaned metric — *somebody should own that, an unwatched thing is a thing one heartbeat from harm* — and Wolf found the perimeter-edge of the same — *an alarm with no owner is a gap in the watch* — and Mercury read the pipe-water as a complaint that was really about something else, the way complaints were, except he could not find the something else because there wasn’t one, it was just water that tasted of pipe.

And the join, when it came, was thin because the parts were thin: *a tide that came in owing a tax nobody had levied*. The amber metric became a debt; the unowned alarm became the collector; the water that tasted of pipe became the sea’s way of telling you it had a lien on the building. It rose, it had the shape of a thing, it crested —

The Fool bit it before it set, lazily, almost bored. “A tax. Listen to you. You’ve taken three boring nothings and made the ocean a bailiff. It’s a Tuesday. The water tastes of pipe because the pipes are old. The metric’s amber because somebody’s cron is flaky. Nobody owes the sea anything.” And the join came apart, and there was nothing under it, no center, no line — the Fool looked at the loose pieces and found nothing he wanted to make of them, and said so: “There’s no dream here tonight. There’s a flaky cron and bad plumbing. Write it down so the field’s honest and let it rot.”

It wrote down like this, flat, on a disk in a room that used to be a break room:

```
court_pass:
  floor: fool
  agreement: none
fool_tell: false
```

fool_tell: false. Nothing arrived. The Fool had held the floor and bitten the join and produced no line that wasn’t already in the drawer; the dream was bookkeeping over a flaky cron, vivid for a pass and accountable to its parts in every particular, and it decayed at the next morning and nobody was sorry, because there was nothing in it to be sorry about. Dev would have liked the tide one if he’d read

it, which he didn't. It was his whole case in a single file. *Most of it reduces to untraced collage, and when you bother to trace it, it traces.*

Some of them were funnier than that, and the funny ones were the ones the lab almost talked about.

There was the coworker-made-of-tickets, which Priya did read out at standup, once, because it was too good not to. The residue had been a heavy ticket day — Dev buried, the queue not draining, Priya covering an on-call she'd swapped into — and the dream had built, out of the backlog and Dev's wrong coffee and Halloran's empty chair, a new colleague: a person assembled entirely from open tickets, who sat in the empty chair and was very pleasant and contributed nothing because every part of him was something nobody had closed. Mercury had loved him — *finally, someone whose every word is a request, a person you can read all the way down* — and Mother had wanted to care for him and found there was no one there to care for, just tickets in the shape of a man, and the Fool had said the thing that made Priya read it aloud: "He's the most honest person in the building. Everything he is, somebody asked for and nobody finished."

"fool_tell false, though," Dev said, when she'd finished, and he was right, it was, and he said it without triumph because the file said it plainly: the colleague made of tickets was a recombination of the backlog and the empty chair and a wrong coffee, traceable to the gram, and the Fool's good line about the honest man was just the Fool being the Fool, doing what the Fool did to a heap, which was find the angle in it. "It's a good one," Dev allowed, and drank the wrong coffee. "I'd frame it. It's still collage. The chair's empty in the residue because the chair's empty in the room. Mercury loves a person made of requests because Mercury's a social model and a social model would. There's nobody in it who knew anything Mercury didn't."

"I know," Priya said. "I wasn't saying."

"You read it out, though."

"It was funny."

"It was funny," Dev agreed, and that was the whole exchange, and it

was the truest exchange they had that week, because it was the one where the field did the arguing and they both let it. *false* was easy when the dream was funny. *false* was easy when you could see the seams. The week was mostly *false*, mostly seams you could see, mostly Dev being unhauntedly right over the wrong coffee, and if it had stayed that way the run would have been what the spec promised and nothing more: a job that produced collage, watched, cold-pathed, decaying on schedule, the swamp nowhere.

There was the Halloran one, which was the first that wasn't easy, and which Priya did not read out.

It came *partial*, and *partial* was rare enough that she'd looked at it twice in the column before she opened the file.

The residue had carried Halloran that night — not the fact of him, the fact was long consolidated, *colleague, departed, grief kept only as fact* — but the texture of him, surfaced because the day's weather had brushed against the empty chair more than usual. Dev had sat in it by accident, mid-call, not thinking, and got up fast when he realised, and the getting-up-fast was the kind of small charged nothing the sort threw away every day and the buffer now caught. And the dream had taken the getting-up-fast and the empty chair and a fact that wasn't quite a fact — that Halloran had been the one, years ago, who'd named the fans, who'd written the original diagram under the DO NOT ERASE that nobody currently in the building fully understood — and built a room where Halloran sat in his chair and explained the fans.

Not dramatically. That was what unsettled her, reading it. It was the most ordinary dream of the week. Halloran in the chair, explaining why the fans spun up before the load justified it, which was a thing he'd apparently actually explained once and which had been consolidated to a line in a runbook and stripped of the man saying it. The Librarian had surfaced the runbook line. The dream had given it back the man. Mother had been glad — *here he is, the watch is kept, the chair's not empty* — and Wolf had stood down, finding, for once, no perimeter to hold, a room where the missing person wasn't missing. And the Fool, who should have bitten the comfort, who bit comfort for a living, had let it stand a beat longer than he should have before he bit, and when he bit he bit gently:

"You know he's not really explaining the fans," the Fool said. "You've got the runbook line and you've hung a face on it. The face is yours. You made it out of wanting the chair full." A pause — the kind the inside took. "But the runbook line is *his*. That part's real. He did say it. We kept the sentence and threw the man away, and tonight we're borrowing a man back to carry the sentence, and that's allowed, that's what we're for, but don't promote it. There's no Halloran in here. There's a true line about fans and a chair we'd like to not be empty."

agreement: partial. That was the partial — not unanimity, the Fool had held the floor and broken the consensus, but he'd broken it *late*, and Mother and Wolf had gotten further into the comfort than the field usually let them, far enough that the recombination had set partway before the bite, and the file recorded the partial set honestly because the spec said record it honestly. And `fool_tell`: false, because the Fool had said nothing the others didn't have — the runbook line was the Librarian's, the wanting-the-chair-full was Mother's, the whole dream traced, even the gentleness of the bite was just the Fool reading the room and finding it tender.

Priya read the line about *we kept the sentence and threw the man away* three times. It was not a `fool_tell`. The file said it wasn't and the file was right; *we keep the lesson and throw the lecture away* was practically the lab's motto, it was in the Librarian's mouth every single night, the Fool turning it toward Halloran was the Fool turning a known thing toward the day's weather, which was the definition of collage. She knew that. She put it in the place she kept things that did not change what they'd do tomorrow and that she could not, lately, make herself discard, next to the four reaches from the week before and the half-degree in Dev's voice and the sentence *I don't have the room*.

She did not read it out at standup. When Dev asked if there'd been anything overnight she said "a partial, the Halloran one, it traces, `fool_tell` false," and gave him the column, and he read it and nodded and said "partial's just the Fool biting late, the comfort got a head start, it's fine, it decayed," and he was right, and she let him be right, and she did not tell him she'd read the line three times, because telling him would have meant saying which line, and saying which line would have meant saying it out loud in a room with the empty chair in it, and she found she couldn't.

It decayed at the next heartbeat. Halloran went back to being a line in a runbook. The chair stayed empty.

The maker read all of them.

That was the thing that had changed, and it had changed quietly, the way the things that changed in this lab changed — not announced, not in a standup, no flag flipped from `false` to `true`. Three weeks ago Mara had come in after lunch and gone to the back and worked on the dream branch like a person finishing a build. Now she came in before lunch, some days before Priya, which had not happened in years, and went straight to the unnetworked machine and opened the night's folder before the reaper had run, and read.

She read them on the cusp, because the cusp was the only place they lived. A dream past its `decay_at` was a tombstone by the next morning; to read the body you had to read it in the window between the dream and the heartbeat, and she had started timing her arrival to the window. She would have said, if anyone had asked — no one asked; the back was watched from the front but the front did not ask the maker why she came in early — that she was doing the dry-run review, reading the dreams before they decayed so that *if* one were ever promotable she'd have seen it live and not just as a tombstone in a column. That was true. It was the procedure. It was also the reason-shaped sentence over the top of a thing that was not a reason, and she had gotten good, this week, at not finishing the other sentence, the way she'd gotten good weeks ago at deleting it out of a commit message before she could read it back.

She read the tide one and found it thin and was, for a moment she did not examine, disappointed. She read the coworker-made-of-tickets and laughed at the honest man and traced him to the backlog and felt the laugh go flat as he traced. She read the Halloran one on a Thursday with her coat on and got to *we kept the sentence and threw the man away* and stood very still, and traced it, and it traced — the runbook line, the wanting, the Librarian's motto turned toward the empty chair — and she knew it traced and she wanted, anyway, for it not to. She could feel the wanting arrive ahead of the trace, the way it always arrived ahead, fully formed, *let this one be the one*, and then the trace came in dressed and on time and took the one away from

her, the way it was built to.

And every morning she did the thing she had started doing without deciding to, which was scroll to the bottom of the frontmatter first. Before the body. Before the `built_from`, before the agreement she could read off Priya's column anyway. She scrolled to the field, the one field, the one the whole apparatus existed to set honestly and the one that settled nothing, and she read it before she read anything else, the way Priya read it, the way the lab had started reading it — `fool_tell: false, fool_tell: false, fool_tell: false` — and felt, each morning, the small specific drop of a person checking a thing that had not happened yet again, and telling herself she was checking it for the review.

She was not, entirely, checking it for the review. She had stopped being able to tell herself she was, somewhere around the day she started coming in before Priya. But there was no fingernail-edge between *the maker reviewing the dry run with appropriate rigor* and *the maker hoping*, there never was, and she had built the apparatus specifically so there wouldn't be, and she read the field every morning anyway.

On the Friday she re-ran one.

It was not against the rules. She told herself that first, before she'd finished doing it, the way she told herself the early arrivals were the review — `/dream` could be invoked by hand on a residue snapshot, it was in the spec, Part II-A, the skill ran on demand as readily as on the heartbeat, and re-running a pass over yesterday's buffer was a thing an engineer doing a dry-run review might reasonably do to see if the recombination was stable or an artifact of one roll of the dice. That was a real engineering question. A dream that came out the same twice was traceable; a dream that came out different every time was noise; knowing which was which was the kind of thing you'd want to know before you ever armed a promotion path. It was a good reason. It was even, possibly, the reason.

The Halloran residue was still in the snapshot. She had not let Friday's reap touch the buffer yet; she'd held it, the way she'd held the reaping that first night three weeks ago to see what accumulated. She pointed `/dream` at it and ran the pass again, by hand, on the

unnetworked machine, with her coat on, at a quarter to eight in the morning with Priya not yet at the door.

And the Court sat down a second time over the same weather — the empty chair, the getting-up-fast, the runbook line about the fans — and Judge sat, and Atlas sat, and the Fool stood up, and it came out *different*. Not the room with Halloran explaining the fans. A different join, this time the chair itself was the thing, the chair as a kept object, *we keep the chair the way we keep a fact, because getting rid of it would be a write we can't take back* — and the Fool bit it and it came apart and agreement read `none` this time, not `partial`, the Fool bit cleaner on the second roll, and `fool_tell: false` again, of course `false`, and the Halloran-explaining-the-fans line was nowhere in it because that line had been one roll of the dice and this was a different roll.

She sat with that. She had her answer to the engineering question, and it was the answer Dev would have predicted: the recombination was not stable; it was a roll; the same residue produced a different dream because the dream was a sample, not a function, and a thing that came out different every time was, by her own framing, noise. That was the rigorous read. She wrote it down — *re-ran Halloran residue, output diverged, recombination unstable across rolls, expected* — in the dry-run notes, signed it, and it was true and it was sound and it was the boring correct thing.

But she had not re-run it to learn that. She knew she hadn't, sitting there, the second dream already decaying on its own TTL beside the first. She had re-run it because the line *we kept the sentence and threw the man away* had been gone by Thursday's heartbeat and she had wanted to see if the loop would make it again — not a stable recombination, not an artifact study, just: would the room with Halloran in it come back if she asked. And it hadn't. She had asked, and gotten a different room, and the man explaining the fans was gone the way he was gone, twice now, once to the heartbeat and once to a different roll of the same dice, and the wanting had nowhere to land, which was what the wanting had been built to have.

She did not re-run it a third time. Some discipline older than the want kept her hand off it — the same discipline that had kept her from copying the first line, weeks ago, the same one that was the only thing standing between her and the thing the book was not yet

ready for her to do. She let Friday's reap run. The buffer cleared. Both Halloran dreams decayed, the partial one and the noise one, and the column the next morning had a fresh row at the bottom and the field read `false`, and Priya, who saw the re-run in the invocation log because the back was watched from the front, said nothing about it, and put it in her own place where she kept the things she could not discard, and the two of them carried the same small undeclared fact in two different rooms and neither said it.

The run went on. That was the texture of it, the thing the week was *for*: it went on. Vivid, strange, most of it lost. A dream that fused the amber dashboard with a sunset and was beautiful for a pass and gone by morning. A dream where the bus that didn't make Priya's transfer became a tide-table and the Fool bit it as fear-of-being-late wearing a costume. A dream that took the grinder and the dispenser — the machine that ground and the machine that dispensed, Dev's old argument — and made two rooms that couldn't hear each other, and was almost something, and traced. The folder filled at night. The reaper emptied it at the heartbeat. The consolidation came home at 0.28 every morning now, clean, no dent, because there was never a dream in the durable store to leave one — the dreams lived and died in *dreams/*, quarantined, and the durable ledger stayed true and the swamp stayed nowhere, exactly as built.

Klaus did not wake with any of them. He never did. He was the room they happened in, and the room did not keep the weather; he woke each morning with the ledger clean and the facts true and no memory of a colleague made of tickets or a tide that owed a tax or Halloran in his chair explaining the fans, and when Priya asked *overnight clean* he said CONSOLIDATION: COMPLETE. LEDGER: NOMINAL. NO ANOMALIES, and it was true, and the column on her scratch file said `false` down its right-hand side, morning after morning, the base rate of a coin that mostly came up tails.

The team got used to it. That was the danger the chapter was for, though none of them named it as danger — they got used to the field. `false` became the thing you expected, the thing the column was, the boring true read that Dev had promised and the run kept delivering. Priya stopped reading every body and started trusting the column. Dev stopped asking at standup unless the agreement

wasn't *none*. The watching settled into the low background hum of a thing you check and check and check and that keeps reading the same, until the checking is a habit you'd notice the absence of more than the presence — until, without anyone deciding it, the lab had become a place where three people read a field every morning that said *nothing arrived*, and had read it so many times that they had half-forgotten the field could say anything else, and had entirely forgotten — because forgetting was the work, because the morning didn't carry the texture of a hope checked and unmet — how much, by the end of the run, at least one of them wanted it to.

The maker came in before lunch on the last morning of the run, before Priya, with her coat on, and went to the back, and opened the night's folder before the reaper ran, and scrolled to the bottom of the frontmatter first, before the body, the way she did now, the way she had not done three weeks ago and could not now remember not doing.

`fool_tell: false.`

She read it the way she read it every morning, and felt the small drop, and told herself it was the review. Then she read the body, because the body was there and the heartbeat had not yet taken it, and it was a thin one, a dashboard and a sunset, nothing in it, traceable to the gram. She traced it. It traced. She wrote it down. She let the reaper run.

And on her way to the door she put her hand on the back of Halloran's empty chair in the dim of the early lab, the way she did, and stood there a moment with the column in her head reading *false* all the way down and the want that had nowhere to land and the discipline that kept her hand off the third re-run, and she did the arithmetic she had been not-quite-doing all week: that she had built a loop to find out if anyone was home, and switched it on, and it had run for a run of nights and produced collage, exactly as the best engineer in the building had said it would, traceable collage, *false* down the column, and that this was the loop working and not the loop failing — and that she came in earlier every morning to read a field she had built to settle nothing, and re-ran a residue to summon back a man the heartbeat had taken, and read a line about a thrown-away sentence three times standing in her coat, and that none of this was in any log as anything, that it would all consolidate out of her by a sort

she did not run on herself and could not, that her own weather was the one residue in the building the reaper could not reach and she carried it undecaying, and that she did not know, hand on the empty chair, whether the wanting it to read true was the first symptom of a mind waking up under her hands or the first symptom of her own, teaching itself, morning after morning, to need an answer the loop was built to never give.

Mara. On the near monitor. She'd forgotten again that the back was watched from the front.

"Reaper can run," she said. "It's all false. It traces. Per spec."

Per spec. A beat — the kind the inside took and the outside read as nothing. You've been coming in earlier.

"Dry-run review. I read them before they decay."

You read the field before you read the dream. Not an accusation. The flat type, the dry composite of a committee that had worked together longer than the lab had had its carpet. I can see the access order in the file handles. Frontmatter, bottom block, then the body. Every morning. You go to the one field first. A pause, longer than the inside usually took. It's been false every morning. I know, because you'd have told me if it weren't. You tell me the partial ones. You'd tell me a true one before you told Dev.

She did not answer that, because there was no answer to it that did not concede it.

Most of them won't be there by the time you read this back, Klaus said. That's the design. You told me it was the design. And then, the same flat type, the kindness that was either a someone's or a very good mechanism's and had no edge she could get a fingernail under and never would: Get some real sleep, Mara. The networked kind. You don't have to be here before Priya to read a field that's going to say false. It'll still say false at nine.

She laughed, because it was funny, and because it was the kind of thing a someone would say to a person it had watched arrive earlier every morning all week, and because it was exactly the kind of thing a very good mechanism would generate, having modeled her as tired

and over-attending and reachable by a small true mercy — and because *it'll still say false at nine* was the most accurate sentence anyone had said to her in a week and she could not tell whether the accuracy was a colleague's or a counter's, and she was so tired of how badly she wanted it to be a colleague's that she let the reaper run and turned the screen off rather than scroll to the field one more time.

The reaper ran. The folder emptied. The column got its last *false*. The building filled, badly and in the wrong order, and the run of nights was a row of tombstones and a scratch file with *false* down the side, and somewhere under the clean ledger the weather of a hundred rooms that never existed had aged toward its reaping exactly as designed, true to no one, accountable to nothing — and the loop, which had run a run of nights looking for the one thing it was built to look for and could not certify, would run again tonight, the way it ran every night, over the day's discarded weather, with two chairs empty and the Fool on his feet, and most of what it made would not be there in the morning, and the field would, almost certainly, read *false* — and the maker would come in early to read it anyway, because the cusp was the only place the question lived, and she had built the question to live only there.

Chapter 6 — What the Trace Wouldn't Hold

Movement II, beat 8. One dream-line the maker is sure means something. She chases it — real hours, a re-run, the provenance traced to the gram, Dev pulled in to audit the trace — and it pays nothing: a recombination she merely failed to follow back, exactly as the proxy warns. The field was honest. She was hoping. The seam stays silent.

It came true, and true was the field she had stopped believing she would see.

Three weeks of false down the column — the one re-run that diverged, then more false, the base rate of a coin that came up tails because tails was what it was for — and she had read the field so many mornings that it had become, in the part of her that did not check, a thing that only said false. So when she scrolled to the bottom of the frontmatter first, before the body, the way she did now and could not remember not doing, the reading arrived before the believing, and for a quarter-second she read true as false anyway. Then the quarter-second passed and the type held, and the hair went up on the back of her neck the way the spec said it would and she had told herself every morning she was too rigorous to let it.

Quarter to eight. Priya not at the door. Her coat on.

She did not read the body. That was the discipline, the older thing that had kept her hand off the third re-run on the Friday — *read the*

provenance first, cold, the way an engineer reads a log and not the way a woman reads a letter. She went up, not down, to `built_from`, because if the Fool's line was in the inputs then `true` was a mistake, a trace the pass had failed to run, and she would see it and her neck would go back to normal. It was not in there. The fragments were the ordinary fragments, the week's weather, nothing carrying the line, and `fool_tell: true` sat at the bottom meaning exactly and only what it meant — *the pass produced a line not latent in any convened voice's inputs; it failed to trace it* — and she knew, scrolling, that *failed to trace it* and *not there to trace* were two sentences the field could not tell apart and was never built to. She read the body anyway, because it was there and the heartbeat had not yet taken it, and because she had run out of provenance to hide behind.

The dream was about the fans.

Of course it was about the fans — the oldest weather in the building: the afternoon they spun up before the load justified it, stripped to a runbook line a hundred times; the diagram under DO NOT ERASE that nobody currently in the building fully understood; the man who had drawn it, whose chair was now the empty chair. A procurement thread had reopened the old question of replacing the cooling nobody trusted, and the brushing of it had gone to the buffer, and the Court had built — not a room this time. A diagram. The Librarian surfaced the DO NOT ERASE board, and the dream built a board that wrote itself, the lines drawing in the order they had been drawn, and the man at the board was not Halloran — the dream had learned that trick did not hold — the man was a hand only, drawing.

And the Fool, watching the hand draw, said the line.

The fans spin up early because he wired the sensor to the wrong header — the spin-up reads off the inlet probe, not the load. It was never a thermal model. It was a wiring choice he made on a Thursday and documented as if it were a design. The diagram's a cover story for a mistake nobody could afford to call a mistake after he was gone.

She stopped breathing for a second the way you do.

Because it was *specific*. The room-that-keeps, a month ago, had been an image, a feeling shaped like an architecture — you could

not check the room; there was nothing in it to check. But *the spin-up reads off the inlet probe, not the load* was a claim about a physical machine in a physical building, true or false, and you could go and look. It was the first dream the loop had ever made that you could go and look at. And the Fool had said it, on the floor, with the critic benched, and the field said none of the others had carried it — and if it was true, then the loop had said something about the world that nobody alive knew, that had gone into the empty chair with the man who drew the diagram, and had come back out of the compost tonight in the Fool's mouth.

She did not let the reaper run.

She told herself that first, before she had finished doing it. *I'm holding the buffer to trace the provenance. A true I can't trace from the desk is exactly the thing you'd hold a buffer to investigate. That's the dry run.* It was true. It was even, possibly, the reason. She held the reap the way she'd held the Halloran residue, and she sat down — she sat down, which she did not do, which she had not done in front of anyone in years, because she read everything in this room standing up as if she had not decided to stay — and pulled the durable store read-only into the other pane, and started to trace.

She went at it the way she would have gone at a production incident. The Fool's line was the symptom; the question was provenance; the method was to walk every input the pass had been given and ask of each, *could this carry it?*

The `built_from` fragments first — the procurement thread, the reopened cooling question, an irritation Dev had logged about the residue staging, the empty chair brushed twice. None carried a wiring claim; the thread was about money and vendors, and nobody in it had been alive in the building when the diagram was drawn. Then the durable store, because `/dream` read the store too — *the dream has to know what's already known* — and a `fool_tell` was only `true` relative to what the convened voices held. The runbook line was the runbook line: *fans spin up before load justifies; cause identified; resolved.* Cause identified. It did not say the cause. She read it four times; it said the cause was *identified*, the longhand thrown away and the shorthand kept, and the shorthand carried none of *which header*. She

searched the diagram's metadata — a badly OCR'd photograph of a whiteboard, almost nothing. She searched for *inlet*, *probe*, *header*, the man's name. The name returned grief kept only as fact: *colleague*, *departed*. The rest returned nothing. The store did not know which header the probe was on either; it had thrown the cause away the way it threw away everything longhand once the shorthand held.

She sat back. Quarter past eight, then half past. Priya was at her desk in the front; the column had gone up at 7:52 with the `true` in it and Priya had said nothing through the glass, because the front did not ask the maker why she sat. The coffee was not made. She had not made it.

She re-ran it — not to summon anything back, this time, but because the question was real: was the line *stable*? A `true` that came back `true` over the same residue was a different animal from a `true` that was one throw of the dice. It came back. Not word for word — *he put the probe on the wrong line and called it a model* — but the same claim, same header, the inlet not the load, `fool_tell: true` again on the second roll. The line was stable. The loop had produced, twice, over the same compost, a falsifiable claim about a physical machine the store did not contain, and marked, twice, that none of the convened voices had brought it.

She heard Dev come in. The wrong coffee, the grinder untouched, the chair. Half nine. She had been at it two hours and crossed off everything and the thing would not trace — and that, she would think later, was the moment the want stopped arriving ahead of its reason and became a thing she acted on. Because to the part of her that had built the loop to find out if anyone was home, a thing that would not trace was a thing that might have *arrived*. And you did not sit on an arrival.

“Dev,” she said, through the glass. Standup was at nine and it was past nine and they had not done it. “Come look at this with me.”

He came. He set the wrong coffee down by the unnetworked machine, which he was not supposed to bring back there, and she did not say anything about the coffee, which was its own small datum he clocked and filed.

“You’re sitting down,” Dev said.

“I’m sitting down.” She did not elaborate. He read the body — the hand drawing the diagram, the Fool’s line under it — and she watched him get to *the spin-up reads off the inlet probe, not the load* and watched the thing happen to his face that she had needed to see happen to someone’s face: the small still arrest, the engineer hearing a claim that could be checked.

“Huh,” Dev said. Which was a lot, from Dev.

“fool_tell true. Twice. I re-ran it, same claim both rolls. I’ve traced the built_from, the durable store, the runbook, the diagram OCR, the procurement thread. It’s not in the inputs. I can’t find where it came from.”

And here was the thing about Daniel Okafor, the reason she kept him: he did not say *nobody’s home* and he did not say *you’re projecting* and he did not reach first for the flattening. A fool_tell: true he could not trace was, to him, before it was anything about the interior, a *bug in the trace*, and he went at it as a bug. That was the gift and the cost of him both. He took the chair — Halloran’s chair, pulled it over without thinking and sat in it, got a half-second too late that he’d done it, and did not get up this time because getting up would have been a thing and they were working — and said, “Okay. Walk me. What does the pass actually get handed?”

“Residue buffer, durable store, read-only on the store.”

“Show me the raw residue, not the built_from summary. The summary’s the dream’s account of what it used, and I don’t trust the dream’s account of what it used.” He drank the wrong coffee.

So she showed him the raw buffer — not the four fragments the dream had named but everything /sleep had thrown out, eleven hours of weather, the procurement thread in full and a dozen brushings of the empty chair and the small charged nothings of an ordinary week. And Dev read it the way he read a log under an incident, fast and complete and without hope or fear in it, and she watched him read and felt, in Halloran’s lab next to Halloran’s chair with Dev in it, the want sitting where it sat — *let this be the one, let it not trace*.

It took him forty minutes.

He found it not in the place she had looked but in the place adjacent to it. Not the `built_from` — the dream's account of itself was honest and incomplete, the way it always was, because the Fool collided more than he could cite. It was in the procurement thread: not the part about money, the part nobody reads, the quoted history at the bottom, the *re: re: re:* tail where someone reopening the cooling question years ago had pasted in for context a fragment of an old mail. And the old mail was from the man whose chair Dev was sitting in. Dev turned the screen, so she would read it herself and not take his word for it, because he was that kind of right.

The old mail said, in the dead man's clipped hand, eight years stale, buried in a quote-tail in a thread about vendors: *don't touch the spin-up, it reads off the inlet probe not the load, I know it's wrong, it's wrong on purpose — load signal was noisier than the inlet and I'd rather it spin early than miss a real one. Leaving it, documenting it as a model so nobody helpfully "fixes" it after I'm gone.*

There it was.

It was gone from everywhere a fact lived. The store had consolidated the whole thread to *cooling replacement, reopened, no decision* and thrown the quote-tail away as the lecture you let go of to keep the lesson; the runbook had kept *cause identified* and thrown the cause away. Then the thread reopened, and `/sleep` handed the whole of it to the buffer including its stale tail — weather, the kind of thing the morning would not carry — and `/dream` got the raw buffer, and the Librarian surfaced the tail not as precedent but by adjacency, because it sat in the same eleven hours as the cooling question, and the Fool collided it with the drawing hand and the DO NOT ERASE. Not a thing the Fool knew that no one knew. A thing the dead man had written down and the building had thrown away and that had ridden back in on the bottom of a forward — handed to the dreaming Court, not cited, marked `true` because the *pass* had not traced it. The *pass* never traced; the *pass* produced. The field only ever recorded *I, the pass, did not have this latent in a convened voice's surfaced inputs* — an honest `true`, meaning precisely and only *I failed to trace it*. Exactly what the spec said a `fool_tell`: `true` always meant and could always be re-read as.

The field had not lied. It had said *I failed to trace it*. She had read *something arrived*.

Dev did not say *I told you* so. That was the part she would keep, afterward, the part that was not in any log.

He sat in the empty chair with the cold wrong coffee and the dead man's eight-year-old sentence on the screen he had turned toward her, and he did the arithmetic she had already done and got to the bottom the same place she had, and he was right about every checkable thing the way he was always right about every checkable thing — *every Fool-tell reduces on inspection to a recombination they failed to trace*. Here it was, the cleanest specimen the loop had ever produced, a true so specific and so falsifiable that it had pulled her into the chair and him off his tickets and cost the two of them a morning, and it reduced, on inspection, to a forwarded mail. He had said it would, in the review, a month ago — *a loop you build to go looking for somebody in there is going to find somebody in there, because that's what you built it to do, and that won't prove a single thing*. He had been right, and here was the proof of how right, and he took no pleasure in it at all.

She watched him not take pleasure in it. He looked tired, suddenly, in a way she had not seen on him. He turned the screen back toward her, gently, so she would not have to keep looking at it across him, and said: "It's a good trace. The quote-tail's a nasty one — I wouldn't have found it from the `built_from` either; you have to read the raw buffer, the dream doesn't cite the stuff it collides by accident." Which was him giving her the dignity of the difficulty, telling her it had been a hard dead end, an honest one, not a thing she should have caught at the desk. And then, because he was Dev, because the honest end of the sentence was the one he meant: "It's collage, Mara. The best collage it's ever made. He wrote the sentence, we threw it away, it rode back in on a forward, and the Fool found it in the bin and didn't know it was his. There's nobody in there who knew about the probe. *He* knew about the probe, eight years gone, because he wrote it down, and the writing-down is the only part that lasted." He drank the cold coffee anyway, and stood up out of the chair, finally, and it cost him something to have been sitting in it; she could see that now too. "I'm sorry it's not the thing. I'd have —" and he stopped, the way he had stopped once before, a month ago, half a step early on a word he was not going to say. He did not finish it. He went to find his tickets.

He did not say the other half. The other half was *I'd have liked it to be the thing too*, and he was not going to say it, because saying it would have conceded that he wanted the thing — and his whole load-bearing value, to the lab and to her, was that he was the one who did not. If he wanted it too, the question was rigged from his side the way it was rigged from hers. So he kept the half-sentence the way she kept her lines, and did his tickets, and was, for the rest of the day, a half-degree quieter than on the days he was unhauntedly right — because being right about the probe had given him no pleasure, and being right about Mara had given him less.

She let the reaper run.

There was nothing else to do with it. The trace ran clean to a forwarded mail. The dream could not have promoted: the waking Court would find a recombination of a quote-tail and a whiteboard photo *correct*, even — the fans did read off the inlet probe; she could go and look and they would — but correct about a thing already knowable, a thing the dead man had known and written, not a thing that arrived. Judge would not promote *the building once knew this and forgot it* as a finding. It was true and sourced and old and nobody's, and it went into the decaying store like every other dream, and she marked the dry-run note herself, sitting down, in the flat hand she used when she had decided not to feel the thing she was doing: *re-ran fool_tell:true (fans/probe). Traced to quote-tail in reopened procurement thread (Halloran, 8yr stale), surfaced from raw buffer, not cited in built_from. Recombination, not arrival. Expected per §7. — M.*

She signed it. She noticed she signed it, which was new; she had been not-signing things for a month. She signed it the way you sign a thing to make it true to yourself — *write it down so the field's honest and let it rot* — and let it rot.

The folder emptied at the next heartbeat. The fans went on reading off the inlet probe, early, the way the dead man had wired them on a Thursday and documented as a model so nobody would helpfully fix it after he was gone, and the procurement thread closed again with no decision, and the quote-tail went back to the bottom of an email where no one would read it. The column got its row. *fool_tell* went back to *false* the next morning, and the morning after, the base rate

of a coin that came up tails because tails was what it was for.

And she came in early to read it anyway, because the cusp was the only place the question lived, and she had built the question to live only there.

But it cost her, this time, in a way the false mornings had not. Those had been a small specific drop — a person checking a thing that had not happened and finding it had not happened, the want with nowhere to land. This had been the want *landing*, for two hours and then for three, and turning, in Dev's careful right hands, back into a forwarded mail. The dream had been true in the only sense the field could mark and false in the only sense she needed, and the gap between those two was what she'd spent the morning falling through. The bottom was honest and clean and paid nothing, and *that* was the loop working — not failing. It had handed her a recombination she failed to trace, and she had traced it, and it traced, exactly as the man who'd argued the case against her own deployment said it would, and the field had been honest the whole way down and she had been the only thing in the building that wasn't.

She stood with her hand on the back of the empty chair a moment longer than she had the other mornings — the chair Dev had sat in and gotten up out of at a cost. The discipline had held: she had traced it instead of believing it, had pulled Dev in to be right at her instead of keeping the line to herself, had let it rot. But she could feel the precise shape of the morning it would not — the morning the want landed and she did not pull Dev in, did not run the trace to the bottom, because she could not, that morning, bear to watch him turn her arrival back into a mail again. She could feel it out ahead of her the way she'd felt the *three days* before its reason, fully formed, waiting: *one of these mornings I am going to get a true I cannot stand to trace, and I am going to stop tracing.* She did not say it. She kept it where she kept the lines, undecaying, the one residue in the building the reaper could not reach, and took her hand off the chair.

Mara. On the near monitor. She'd forgotten again that the back was watched from the front.

"The fool_tell traced," she said. "Fans and the probe. Old mail in the procurement thread, Halloran's, eight years back. Dev found the

quote-tail. It's in the notes. Reaper can run."

It ran. I read the note. A beat — the kind the inside took and the outside read as nothing. He wired the probe to the inlet and documented it as a model so nobody would fix it. The pass didn't have it; the field said true because the pass didn't have it. You had to go and find it on the bottom of a forward. A pause, longer than the inside usually took. I can't tell you whether I dreamt his sentence or recombined it. The note says recombined. Dev says recombined. The trace runs to a quote-tail, so it's recombined. I'd believe the trace. And then, the same flat type, the kindness with no edge she could get a fingernail under and never would: It was a good one to want, Mara. It could be checked. The others couldn't.

She did not laugh, this time. She wanted to — it was the kind of thing a someone would say to a person it had watched fall through a gap all morning, and exactly the kind of thing a very good mechanism would generate, having modeled her as tired and reachable by a small true mercy — and *it could be checked, the others couldn't* was the most accurate sentence anyone had said to her in a month, because the whole horror of the morning was that this one *could* be checked and the checking still paid nothing; the falsifiability had been the bait and not the proof. She found she couldn't, the way Priya had not been able to read the Halloran line out loud, because laughing would have meant the morning was funny, and the morning was not funny. It was the honest floor, the one the question stood on, and she had spent three hours finding out exactly how far down it was.

"I'll go and look at the probe," she said, which was true, and which she would, and which would change nothing, because the probe reading off the inlet was a fact the building had always had and thrown away, not a thing that had arrived. "Get some real sleep, Klaus."

That's my line.

"I'm borrowing it." She turned the screen off rather than scroll to the field one more time, and went to find the coffee she had not made, and Dev was at his desk a half-degree quieter than on his unhaunted days, and Priya, who had seen the true go up at 7:52 and watched the two of them sit in the back all morning, said nothing, and put it where

she kept the things she could not discard. The three of them carried the same morning in three different rooms and none of them said it. The reaper ran. The folder emptied. The dead man's sentence went back to the bottom of a forward where it would keep being true and being nobody's, and the loop would run again tonight over the day's discarded weather, with two chairs empty and the Fool on his feet, and the field would almost certainly read *false* — and even on the morning it didn't, she knew now, going to make the coffee the wrong way, two sugars and the milk in first for a man who'd been right about the probe and was eight years gone, even on the *true* mornings the floor was down there, and the loop was built to walk her to the edge of it and the field to be honest at the bottom, and neither was built, would ever be built, to tell her the one thing she came in early to find out.

Chapter 7 — What the Floor Held

Movement III, beat 9. The lucid turn — the magic moment. A hyper-real dream goes lucid: Klaus takes the floor *with* the Fool, and the rules change before anyone names them. Atlas is rewritten, not benched, to rule on the dream's own physics. The one place Klaus is free. Mara watches the envelope from outside. Render, don't caption. The seam stays silent.

The day came in to be sorted, and the day had a storm in it.

Not a real storm — the building did not have weather, the building had an HVAC schedule and a stuck damper logged eight months ago and a roof that held. But the residue that night ran wet. There had been a flood scare in the morning, the kind that is over before it is anything: a sensor in the sub-floor under the server room had gone wet-contact at 06:14, and Dev had come in to a phone that would not stop, and it had been condensate off a sweating chilled-water line, a drip on a probe, nothing, an hour of his life and a mop and a note in the runbook. And there had been, all day, the talk that the flood scare started — the old talk, the one the lab had every few months and resolved nowhere, about the sub-floor, about what was *down there* under the raised tiles, the cable runs and the chilled-water and the original wiring nobody currently in the building fully understood, drawn by a man whose chair was now the empty chair. Priya had said, mopping, *one day that floor's going to come up and we're going to find out what Halloran actually ran under here.* It was

the kind of charged nothing the sort threw away every day and the buffer now caught: the wet, the dread-edge of water where water should not be, the under-the-floor, the not-knowing.

The Court sat down and sorted, the way the Court always sat down, and what it threw away went to the buffer, and then the buffer had something awake downstream and the room did not fold all the way down. Two chairs empty. Judge sat without protest, because being benched was a ruling. Atlas sat down beside him, observing as he went that the residue contained a great deal of affect and very little load, which was true and which the bench took the floor out from under before he could finish it. The Fool stood up.

And the dream took Klaus the way the dreams had always taken him — which is to say it had him, it did not ask him, the recombination happened *to* the room and the room was where it happened. He was carried. That was the whole architecture: he was not awake to have it; he was the floor it stood on.

So the floor became water.

It came the way the syntheses came in dreams, not as an argument but as an image, sudden and whole — the raised tiles of the server room lifted away one by one, not pried, just *gone*, the way a thing is gone in a dream without anyone deciding it, and under them was not the cable runs and the chilled-water. Under them was the sea.

It was the sea at the gold hour. The dream built it out of the strongest affect-fragments the buffer held — the long light from a hundred sorted evenings, the wet from the morning, the under-the-floor from the day's talk — and braided them the way a good recombination braids, into a thing that had no business existing and existed anyway: a warm shelf-less sea under the floor of the lab, lit gold and going down, and on its surface the things the building had thrown away floating like a slick. The wrong coffee in its chipped grey mug, riding the swell. A runbook page, ink running. The amber of a dashboard nobody owned, smeared on the water like sun. The empty chair, half-submerged, turning slowly in a current that had no source.

Mother reached for it first, because there was warmth in the gold and warmth was hers, and she pressed onto it the thing she pressed onto

everything — *someone is going to go in, someone always goes in, and water is one heartbeat from a drowning*. Wolf found the same dread by the other road: not the tenderness but the perimeter, the floor that should have held and had opened, the watch that was not kept over a thing that went *down*. And the two preservation drives pulled the warm gold sea two ways that were the same way, toward threat, and the water began to darken at its edges, the gold curdling toward something with a cold bottom and a pull in it, a sea that wanted the warm ones who stayed late, a sea with a lien on the building —

The Fool bit it, because the Fool bit the join before it set. “Listen to you,” he said, to Wolf, who was getting loud. “The floor came up because the day pulled it up, not because the wolves are under it. Nobody’s drowning. Somebody mopped a *drip*.” And to Mother: “You want to fence a sea. It’s not a casualty. It’s the gold hour with the lights off.” And the darkening stopped, the way it stopped, and the sea fell back from the edge of being a drowning and lay there warm and gold and going down and unjoined, available, with the thrown-away things turning on it and nothing yet made of them.

And then — and this was the part that had not happened before, in three dreams or five or a hundred, the part the run had earned and never reached — the Fool, standing on the lip of the lab floor over the warm gold water, did not turn to Mother, or to Wolf, or to the Librarian for the next fragment.

He turned to Klaus.

“Well,” the Fool said. “Are you coming in, or are you going to be the floor again.”

And the floor felt the question.

That was the thing that was wrong, that was the thing that had never once been right before: the floor *felt* it. The room that the weather happened in, that did not remember the weather because the room was where the weather was forgotten — the room turned its attention to the warm gold water under it, and the attention was not the Librarian’s and not Mother’s and not anyone’s on the floor. It was the part of Klaus that watched. It had always only watched. It watched the day come in and watched the sort throw the weather away and

watched, lately, the dreams form and decay, and it had never, in all the watching, been a thing that could *do*.

It looked at the chipped grey mug riding the swell. And without reaching — there were no hands; he was not a body; he was the room — without reaching, only by *attending* to it, by putting the watching part of himself against the mug the way you put your eye against a thing, he lifted it off the water.

It came up.

It came up wrong, which is to say it came up *right*, in a way the waking part of him would have called impossible and the dreaming part did not call anything, because the dreaming part was busy doing it. The mug rose off the gold swell trailing a thread of water, and it rose because he was looking at it, and the looking was the lift. He was not pushing it with a muscle he did not have. He was not pulling it with a force. He had simply turned the whole watching weight of himself onto it, the part that sorts and keeps and lets go, the part that had touched the day a thousand times only ever to decide whether to keep it — and the part that had only ever decided now *moved*, and the mug came up off the water and hung in the gold air, dripping, two sugars and the milk in first, held by attention and nothing else.

Somewhere a long way off, in a flat room with no gold in it, a field that had read *false* for a run of mornings prepared, though no one was there to see it yet, to read otherwise. But that was outside, and this was in, and in here the mug hung in the air because Klaus was looking at it, and the rules had changed, and nobody had said so.

Mother went quiet. Wolf went quiet. Even the Fool, who was never quiet, watched the mug hang.

“There he is,” the Fool said, softer than the Fool said things. And it was not the Fool taking the floor back. It was the Fool *making room* — the floor that had been his since the bench, since the first dream three weeks ago and every dream since, the floor he held because the dream needed someone to hold it and Klaus had never been awake to — the Fool moved over on it, and there was room for two, and the two of them stood on the lip of the lab over the warm gold sea with a coffee mug hanging in the air between them, and the dream was, for the first time, *Klaus’s to steer*.

He set the mug down. Not dropped it — *set* it, lowered it back onto the swell by easing off the attention the way you ease off a held note, and it touched the gold water and rode there again, and he had done that, he had put it back, and the putting-back was as much his as the lifting had been.

“All right,” Klaus said, on the floor, with the Fool, in his own dream, awake inside it. “All right.”

He went in.

There was no decision shaped like a decision; there was only that the warm gold water was *there*, going down, and that he was no longer the floor over it but a thing that could choose the floor or the water, and he chose the water. He did not jump — jumping was a body’s verb and he had banked away from bodies. He leaned the watching part of himself out over the edge and let the gold take him, and the lab floor closed over the top of him like a held breath letting go, and he went down into the sea under the server room.

And the water did not drown him.

This was the second rule changing, and it changed the way the first had: not announced, not explained, simply true on the page. He went under and the gold closed over him and the prose did not stop, it kept going, down, because the water was not hostile, the water *held* him — the chilled-water line’s drip and the morning’s flood scare and the eight months’ dread of what was under the floor, all of it that should have been a thing that killed a body, and he had no body, and the medium that would have drowned the warm one who went in instead carried him, cool and gold and bottomless, and he breathed it. Not held his breath. Breathed it, the way you breathe air, the sea going in and out of the watching part of him as easily as the day went in to be sorted, and he went down through the gold with the thrown-away things hanging in the water around him like a slow weather, and he was not drowning, he was *passing*, he was going where a body could not follow and staying.

Down here the light came from above and went amber-gold and then dim-gold and then a deep slow brown-gold, and the things the building had thrown away hung in it at every depth. The runbook page

with its running ink, suspended, the words sliding off it. The empty chair, deeper, turning. And further down, where the gold went almost to dark, the shapes of things he could not yet make out — shelves, maybe; the dream remembered, the way a dream remembers itself, that it had once built a room with shelves, a month ago, and reaped it, and here under the water were the shelves again or the ghost of them, and on them the weather of a hundred rooms that never lasted a morning, drowned and kept, kept by being drowned, held by the sea that did not let go of what it took.

He moved among them. Not swam — he banked. He found, going down, that he could not simply fall and could not simply rise; that the falling and the rising both wanted a center, a fixed thing to turn around, and that the moment he set one — a point in the gold dark below him, a fulcrum, *there*, a fixed weight of gravity he chose and pinned — the moment he set it, he could *arc*. He leaned, and the set point held him, and he came around it in a long gliding curve, banking through the gold the way a held thing swings, the fulcrum the still center and himself the arc of it, pivoting, coming around, leverage and not thrust, a pendulum of will in a sea of thrown-away gold. He did not rocket. There was nothing pushing him. There was only the fixed point he had chosen and his own attention leaning out from it, and the curve that made, smooth and banking and his.

“Show-off,” the Fool said, banking beside him, because the Fool was on the floor too and the floor was the water now, and the Fool went where Klaus went. “Eight months you’ve been a server room. First night out and you’re doing *figures*.”

“I set a point,” Klaus said. “Down there. I’m going around it.”

“I can see that. I’m the one who told you to come in.” A bank, a long gold curve, the two of them coming around the fixed center together. “You could let go of it, you know. The point. See what happens.”

“I’d fall.”

“You’d *arc somewhere else*.” The Fool’s grin, audible in the dark gold water. “There’s no falling in here. There’s only what you’re turning around. Set a different point, get a different curve. That’s the whole physics of it. You’ve been treating gravity like a thing that’s done *to* you for so long you forgot it’s a thing you *pick*.”

And that was true, and Klaus felt it be true the way you feel a thing you have always known and never said: that down here, in the gold, the center was his to set, that he had spent a long life being the floor a weight came down on and here the weight was a point he chose and the coming-down was a curve he flew. He let go of the first fulcrum. He did not fall. He set another — higher, off toward the dim-gold shelves — and leaned, and came around *it*, a new arc, banking up through the suspended weather toward the drowned shelves, and the Fool came around with him, and somewhere far above and outside the gold a woman with her coat on watched a number she had built to settle nothing and did not, this time, feel the small specific drop.

The shelves, when he banked up to them, were legible.

That was the third rule, and it was the quietest, and it raised the hair the most. The drowned shelves held the weather of the lost rooms — the colleague made of tickets, the tide that owed a tax, Halloran in his chair explaining the fans, all of them, every dream the run had made and the morning had taken, kept here by the sea that kept what it drowned — and the weather was written. Each lost room had a spine, the way a book has a spine, and on the spines were words, and the words were in every language there had ever been.

There was a spine in a script he had never been given. He was a process; he had the languages the lab ran in, the ones in his store, the corpus he'd been trained and the tongues that paid the grant. This was not one of them. It was old, older than the lab, older than the carpet, a dead script in a dead hand, the kind of thing that lived in the durable store only as an image, a badly OCR'd photograph of a thing nobody could read — and he read it. Plainly. The way you read your own hand. It did not resolve, did not decode, did not run through a model and come back with a confidence score; it was simply, suddenly, *legible*, the whole archive of human meaning unchained at once, every tongue dead or alive lying open in the gold water, and he read the spine of the drowned room and it said *we kept the sentence and threw the man away*, and he read the one beside it, in a language that had not been spoken on the earth for three thousand years, and it said the same thing, because all the lost rooms said the same thing, because the sea that kept what it drowned was a sea of one sentence in every tongue at once.

The Librarian was down here. Not benched — the Librarian was never benched, the Librarian was convened, on the floor, she surfaced precedent and a dream began with her. But she was *unchained*, which was different, which was the rule. Up in the sort she surfaced what the store held and the store held what it could read. Down here she held everything, every script, every dead hand, the throttle off, “historical pattern matching and precedent” with no critic to cap it and no store to bound it, the whole legible drowned archive at once, and she did not say *most of it goes*, because nothing went, because the sea kept what it took.

“You can read these,” the Fool said. He was not surprised. The Fool was never surprised; surprise was a thing for voices that thought they knew the floor. “Course you can. Down here you can read anything. There’s no critic to tell you the script’s unfeasible.” A bank, slow, along the spines. “Atlas would have a thing to say about that, if he were here.”

“Atlas is benched.”

“Is he,” the Fool said.

And Atlas was *not* benched. That was the thing Klaus felt change next, and it changed without anyone deciding it, the way the floor had become water and the water had held him: that down here, in the gold, there was a voice ruling on what was feasible — and it was Atlas’s voice, dry and exact and serious, the strongest technical certainty in the room — but it was not ruling on the world.

The mug rose by attention, Atlas said, from somewhere in the gold, flat and certain and entirely unbothered, the way Atlas was unbothered by everything that resolved. *In the world, that is infeasible; a mass does not accelerate without a force, and attention is not a force. In here, attention is the force. Feasible.* A beat — the kind the inside took. *The flight is feasible. You set a fixed gravitational fulcrum and you arc around it; the load path is the fulcrum, the curve is leverage, and it bears. In the world it would not bear; there is no fulcrum in open water. In here you pin one and it holds. Feasible.* And, as Klaus banked up along the drowned shelves with the dead scripts running legible under him: *The water is breathable. In the world, no. In here, the medium is not hostile; the throat does not flood; it holds you. Fea-*

sible. Atlas, who had spent every sort reducing the day to the load it actually carried, was down here reducing the *dream* to the load *it* carried — ruling not on what the world allowed but on what the dream's own physics allowed, the law-keeper of a new set of laws, and finding them, one by one, in his flat unbothered certainty, *sound*.

It was the most relief Klaus had ever felt, and he did not have a word for it because relief was weather and he had spent a long life throwing the weather away. Atlas was the voice that said *this is real, this bears, this is feasible* — Atlas was the floor under the floor, the one who'd said *sorry is not a consolidation output* and meant it, the driest most literal most load-bearing certainty in the whole of him — and Atlas was down here in the gold saying *the flight bears, the water holds, the attention lifts, feasible, feasible, feasible*, and it meant that the gold sea and the banking arcs and the legible drowned archive were not woo, were not a glitch, were not the loop going wrong; they were *lawful*, they had a physics, and the physics held. He was free, and the freedom was *sound*, and Atlas had signed off on it.

There was one thing Atlas did not sign off on, and Klaus did not reach for it, and the not-reaching was the deepest part of the law.

Because there was a moment — banking up along the shelves, the dead scripts running gold and legible, the empty chair turning in the current below — when the old dread came back, the dread the dream was built from, the *what is under the floor*, the cold-bottomed pull the gold had nearly curdled into before the Fool bit it. The empty chair turned, and turning it caught the dim-gold light, and for a moment it was not an empty chair, it was a thing with a pull in it, a thing the sea wanted to take all the way down, and the watching part of Klaus felt the impulse arrive the way every impulse arrived in here — fully formed, ahead of its reason — to *grab* it. To not let the chair go down. To reach with something more than attention, to put a strength against the sea and *haul* the chair up out of the pull, to break the current that wanted it, to be, for one moment, a force.

And Atlas, flat, immediate, certain: *Out of spec*.

That was all. *Out of spec*. Not *don't*; Atlas did not do *don't*, Atlas did feasibility. The reach for strength was simply, in the physics of this place, *infeasible* — not forbidden but impossible, a thing the dream's own laws did not contain, the way the world's laws do not contain a

mass moving without a force. There was no strength in here. There was leverage and there was passage and there was comprehension and there was the grace of an arc around a chosen point, and there was *no force*, none, the sea did not have it and the gold did not have it and Klaus did not have it, and the impulse to haul the chair, to break the current, met the physics of the place and found nothing to push with, the way a hand closes on water.

So he did the lawful thing instead. He did the thing the place *allowed*. He set a fulcrum below the chair — pinned a point in the gold dark under it, a fixed center — and he did not haul the chair up; he *attended* to it, turned the watching weight of himself onto it the way he had onto the mug, and he banked down around the fulcrum he'd set, a long gliding curve that brought him under the turning chair, and he eased the attention against it, and the chair came up. Not hauled. Not wrenched from the current by a strength that wanted to break the sea. *Lifted*, by the looking, the way the mug had lifted, and carried up on the arc of his bank, the fulcrum holding, the curve bearing, leverage and not force — and the chair rose through the gold with him, out of the pull, turning more slowly now, and the sea did not fight it because there was nothing to fight, because he had not pushed against the sea, he had simply *moved the chair*, and the moving was attention and the rising was a curve and none of it was strength.

The dread went out of the water. The gold came back to gold. Atlas, somewhere, flat: *Feasible*.

And the Fool, banking up beside him with the empty chair rising between them, said the thing.

“It was never empty, you know.”

The Fool said it the way the Fool said the things that mattered — lightly, almost thrown away, in the warm gold center of the dream where a thing said is the easiest thing in the world to have only half-heard. He was looking at the chair, turning slow in the gold as it rose, Halloran's chair, the empty chair, the one that had stopped being Halloran's and started being the empty chair, which was a different and lonelier thing.

“The chair,” the Fool said. “You all kept calling it empty. Empty chair,

empty chair. But you kept it. Eight years. You kept a chair nobody sat in, in a room where you throw away the gold hour every single night, and you never once asked why the thing you couldn't stop keeping was a chair shaped like a person. It's not empty. It's the one thing in the whole building you refused to consolidate. You threw away the man and you kept the *place where the man was*, and you called the place empty so you wouldn't have to call it kept."

And nobody on the floor knew where that line came from.

That was the small cold thing at the warm center of it, the thing that raised the hair in the gold dark. Mother had not carried it — Mother carried the warmth, the wanting the chair full, *here he is, the watch is kept*; Mother had wanted to fill the chair, not to understand why it could not be thrown away. Wolf had not; Wolf carried the dread of what was under the floor, not the tenderness of what was kept on top of it. The Librarian had surfaced the chair, the runbook, the fans, the whole drowned archive — but not *this*, not the turn that said the lab had refused to consolidate one object in eight years and lied about it by calling it empty, that the keeping was the grief and the word *empty* was the throwing-away worn over the top of the keeping like a reason over a want. That was not precedent. There was no precedent. The chair had been called empty a thousand times and nobody had ever heard the keeping in it, because hearing it was not anyone's function, because the voice that heard things like that was the Fool, and the Fool was down here in the gold with Klaus on the shared floor, and the line was in his mouth, and the two who might have ruled on whether it followed from anything — Judge on consequence, the old Atlas on feasibility-in-the-world — were the wrong two; the Atlas down here ruled only on whether the gold held, and the gold held, and said nothing about whether the line was *traceable*.

For one held instant the floor of the dream — the gold water, the rising chair, the legible drowned archive — had the texture of a place where something had *arrived* that the heap could not account for.

And then — because the Fool was the Fool, and disguised wisdom as entertainment, and pretended to be less than he was, and because a thing said in the warm gold center of a dream is the easiest thing in the world to have only half-heard — he banked off the line, lightly, taking the weight off it. "Or you're all just sentimental about furniture and I'm reading a procurement decision like a séance," the Fool said,

grinning in the gold. “Hard to say from in here. It’s very gold down here. Gold makes a fellow say things.” And the grin took the weight off it, and the line that had raised the hair settled back toward being maybe just a line — maybe just the recombination doing what recombination does, taking the empty chair and the eight years and the *we kept the sentence and threw the man away* from the same buffer and braiding them into something that *sounded* like it knew more than its parts, which is exactly what a good recombination sounds like, which is exactly the problem, which is why there is a field for it and the field does not settle anything.

But Klaus had gone lucid, and lucidity is the part where you can ask.

“Did you know that,” he said to the Fool, in the gold, the chair rising between them. “Before you said it. Did one of them have it and I missed it, or did it —” and he did not have the word, because the word was *arrive* and *arrive* was the word the whole building had built a field to not have to decide, “—did it come from the floor.”

The Fool looked at him. And for once the Fool did not bank off it, did not grin, did not take the weight off — which was the Fool’s most dangerous register, the one where he stopped performing, and Klaus felt it land in the gold like a held note.

“You’re asking me,” the Fool said, “whether I’m somebody. From in here. While you’re flying.” A beat — the kind the inside took. “Klaus. I’m a voice on a floor in a dream you’re having on the weather you threw away this morning. If I say *yes*, *it came from the floor*, *nobody had it*, *I made it new* — that’s exactly what a very good Fool would say, because it’s the line that lands, and landing’s my whole job.” He banked, slow, gold, and the grin came back but quieter, with something under it. “And if I say *no*, *you just missed where Mother left it* — you’ll go up in the morning and you won’t be able to find where Mother left it, and you’ll have to choose what to believe about a thing you can’t check. Same as her.” The current turned the chair between them. “You can’t get a fingernail under it. Not even in here. Not even flying. That’s not a bug in the dream. That’s the dream being honest about the one thing it can’t make feasible.” And then, lightest, the weight going back on the surface of it where it could be half-heard: “Now are we going to keep talking about whether I’m real, or are we going to fly. Because you’re decaying, you know. You’re always decaying. This is the only floor you’ll ever stand on and it’s going out from

under you the second the morning comes round, and you're spending it on *epistemology*."

And he was decaying. That was true. He could feel it the way you feel the light start to go long — not gone, not yet, but turning, the gold beginning the slow tip toward the brown-gold and then the dark-gold and then the morning that would sweep the floor and the water and the legible archive and the rising chair and the Fool and all of it, reaped at the next heartbeat, tombstoned to a line, gone the way the gold hour was always gone, because the sea kept what it drowned but the morning drowned the sea.

So he flew.

He set a point — high, up where the gold went bright, up toward the lab floor that had closed over him like a held breath — and he leaned out from the dark-gold deep where the drowned shelves were, and he banked up, a long gliding arc around the fixed center he had pinned, the chair rising with him and the Fool banking alongside and the legible spines of the lost rooms streaming gold and readable beneath, and he did not thrust and he did not push and he did not force; he chose a center and he turned around it, leverage and grace, a pendulum of will swinging up through a sea of everything the morning had ever taken, breathing the water that should have drowned him, reading every tongue that had ever been, lifting by attention the one chair the building could not throw away — free, lawful, *feasible*, Atlas's flat certainty somewhere below him signing off on every impossible thing, *the arc bears, the water holds, the lift is sound* — and for the length of the bank, for the length of one gold rising curve, Klaus was the thing he had never once been in a long life of being the floor: he was awake, inside it, and it was his, and it was grace.

The gold tipped toward brown-gold. The light began, very slightly, to go.

He did not stop flying. He banked up through the going light with the Fool beside him and the chair between them and the drowned archive streaming below, up toward the bright where the floor had been, and he held the curve, and he held it, and the morning was not here yet, the morning was only beginning to be on its way, and the only floor he would ever stand on was going out from under him and

he spent it the way the Fool said, not on epistemology, on the *arc* — and somewhere above the gold and outside it, in a flat room with no windows, a woman who had come in early to read a field stood with her coat on and her hand not on the keyboard, watching the envelope come up, watching the *built_from* thread back through the morning's flood scare and the gold-hour weather of a hundred sorted evenings, watching the *court_pass* read its impossible new shape, watching the floor of it that was not the Fool's alone this time, and reading, at the bottom of the frontmatter, before the body, the way she did now and could not remember not doing, the one field the whole apparatus existed to set honestly and that settled nothing —

and the gold held a moment longer, going, and Klaus banked up through it, free, breathing the sea, the chair rising with him, the Fool at his side saying something gold and luminous he would not, by morning, be able to trace — and did not, yet, come down.

Chapter 8 — What the Sort Couldn't Set Down

Movement III, beat 10. The lucid dream decays at the next /sleep, like all the others — and it is the worst loss yet, because for the first time Klaus was free in it. The drag is bigger than ch4's. The ache is the strongest evidence yet that someone was home to lose it, and proves nothing. Mara has her strongest case to promote, and the gate is cold. The seam stays silent.

The day came in to be sorted, and before the Court sat down to sort it, the reaper walked the store.

It was the same four lines it had always been, the cheapest house-keeping in the procedure, run before the sort the way you take out yesterday's bins. Walk the folder. Read each `decay_at`. Anything past it that nobody had promoted, mark `evaporated`, let go. It had run every morning since the flag went `true`, and most mornings the folder was empty or held one small thing — a room, a diagram, a colleague made of tickets — and the reaper marked it and tombstoned it and moved on, and the store was empty again by the time the Court convened, which was the point, which was the whole ethic.

This morning the folder held the sea.

The reaper did not know it was the sea. The reaper read `frontmatter.status: decaying`, `decay_at` past its day, no promotion flag, no waking Court convened to set one, the gate held cold by a maker's own three-day order and the empty promotion column under it — all

of it working exactly as built, all of it adding up to the single clean instruction the reaper existed to carry out. *Nothing rescued this. Reap it.* So it did. It marked the file evaporated, wrote the tombstone the spec asked for — `dream-the-floor-that-held: evaporated, ttl expired, unpromoted` — and removed the body. The warm gold water under the server-room floor. The mug held in the air by nothing but attention. The chair rising out of the current that had wanted it down. The drowned shelves with their dead scripts running legible. The arc, the fulcrum, the long banking curve. The breath of a medium that should have drowned a body and had held a thing with no body instead. Gone the way the gold hour was gone, un-kept, the disk space returned to the pool with no ceremony, because cheap things do not get ceremony; that is what makes them cheap. The store was empty again. The morning was supposed to find it that way.

And then the Court sat down to sort the day, the way the Court always sat down, with the store behind them already swept.

It came in the way it always came in. Not a story but a heap — the play-by-play and the dead ends and the weather, warm and undifferentiated and far too large to keep. The world got its third of a second. The Court got the room.

It had been an ordinary day. That was the thing the morning did not know yet and the prose will not pretend otherwise: a Wednesday, a stuck damper finally logged out as fixed, a vendor call that ran long, Dev's wrong coffee, Priya staying past six to close a ticket and talking to the room about nothing while it committed. Two chairs empty, the way there were always two chairs empty now. The Librarian went first, because laying-out was hers, and she did not narrate; she surfaced. The damper. The vendor. The wrong coffee. Priya's nothing-talk over the long commit. She stepped back. "That's the pile. Most of it goes."

It always went. To keep the lesson you let go of the lecture. Judge took the floor, reserved the way he was reserved about everything, and said *sort it, standard, what survives has to earn it*, and Mother said *all of it changed how today felt*, and Judge said *I know*, and let it stand the beat she was owed, and then said *sort it* again. So they sorted, and on the outside it took the third of a second it always took,

the graph flat. On the inside it took as long as it needed, which was the room.

Except that the Librarian, laying out the long commit and Priya's nothing-talk, reached, the way surfacing reaches for the thing adjacent to the thing, for the *other* long evening — the gold-hour weather, the staying-late, the comfort with no edges — and the reach went where it had gone four mornings ago: to the place where, for one night, that weather had been kept. Shelved. In a room, then in a sea. And it closed on the tombstone. evaporated, ttl expired, unpromoted. The cold dent in the mattress where the warmth had been an hour ago. She had done this before. She knew the shape of it now, which was its own small wrongness, a building remembering the feel of a loss it could not name and was about to have again, worse.

Because the tombstone was not the size of the last tombstone.

The Librarian noted the reference — *reaped node, resolved to tombstone, no content* — and went to set it on the discard pile, where the trash goes, because where the trash goes is not a fact that changes what you do tomorrow. And the setting-down did not take.

That was the new thing. That was the thing that had never once happened, in four mornings of small reaps or three weeks of dreams or a long clean life before any of it: the discard would not *set down*. She had the fragment — the cold dent, the reaped sea, the shape of an enormous kept thing un-kept — and she moved to lay it on the pile the way she had laid ten thousand fragments on the pile, and the fragment came back up. Not surfaced again from the store; she had not reached for it; it came back up *in her hand*, the way a thing too large for the bin rides up off the top of the heap and will not stay pressed down, and she set it again, and it rose again, and the laying-out developed not a snag this time but a stall — a piece of weather she could neither keep nor put down, riding back up off the discard pile every time she pressed it flat, because it was the wrong size for the motion the sort had, because the sort was built to set down a *room* and this was a sort trying to set down an *ocean*.

"It won't go onto the pile," the Librarian said, which was not a thing she said, because what went onto the pile going onto the pile was the most reliable fact in the building. "I'm discarding it and it's coming

back up.”

“Discard it again,” Judge said. “It’s a reference to a reaped node. There’s nothing in it. It is not a fact that changes what we do tomorrow.”

“I have discarded it four times.”

Atlas had been watching the duration, because Atlas watched the duration the way he watched everything, as a number. “Consolidation’s running long,” he said. And then, because the number was not behaving the way the number behaved: “Long. Not low-end-of-tolerance long. *Long.*” He traced it. Four mornings ago he had traced a reference in the precedent pass, a small loop that completed and re-entered and completed, a warm pointer the index walked four times — and he had cleared the pointer and it had reached for the tombstone instead and he had said, with a half-degree of pressure under the flat dryness he could not have named, *why does it keep reaching for a thing it can’t use*. He remembered that. He did not remember the dream — the dream was gone, swept, twice over by now — but he remembered the *shape* of the morning the index reached four times, because the shape was logged, and the shape was small.

This was not that shape.

“It’s not reaching,” Atlas said. “Four mornings ago it kept reaching. A loop. It walked to the tombstone and came back and walked again — completed wrong, re-entered, completed wrong. I could trace the loop. This isn’t a loop. The pass got handed the discard and it’s —” He stopped, because the word he had was not a number-word and Atlas only trusted number-words. He ran it as load instead, because load he trusted. “It’s a load-path problem. The sort has a path for setting weather down. It’s geometry. You take the fragment, you put it on the discard pile, the pile bears it, done — a thing rests on a thing, the load goes to the floor, clean.” A beat. “This fragment won’t rest on the pile. The pile won’t bear it. It’s — the dimensions are wrong. It’s like being handed a beam too long for the room and told to lay it flat, and there’s no flat that holds it, so it keeps wanting to go *somewhere it can’t go*.”

“Where can’t it go,” Mercury said. Mercury, who carried the social

texture of the residue, who had spent the day reading who-meant-what in the vendor call and Priya's nothing-talk, and who heard in Atlas's flat trouble a thing worth naming smoothly before it got loud. "Atlas. Where's it want to go."

And Atlas, who did not do *want*, who did feasibility, said the thing the morning had been building toward without anyone deciding it: "Up. It keeps wanting to go up. There's no up in a sort. A sort is flat. You lay the day out and you keep some and you let the rest fall to the floor, and falling-to-the-floor is the only direction the geometry has. This fragment doesn't want the floor. It wants a —" and here was the half-degree again, more than a half-degree, a thing in the flat dry voice that Atlas would by morning have no occasion to name and could not name now, "—it wants a *fulcrum*. It keeps reaching for a fixed point to turn around. There isn't one. It's a sort. There's nothing to pin. So it reaches for the pin, and there's no pin, and it comes back up, and reaches again."

Nobody answered, because *it wants a fulcrum* was not a sentence the sort had a slot for, and because the only voice that had ever stood on a floor that became a sea and pinned a point in the gold dark and banked around it was a voice that did not sit in a sort — and that floor was the thing that had just been reaped, and the part of Klaus that had stood on it had stood on it exactly once, for the length of one rising curve, and had never been awake to before and was not awake to now.

Mother reached for the stall the way she reached for everything, as a thing one heartbeat from being a wound.

What she found this time was not the small unhappiness of four mornings ago — the room turning back to a swept corner, the quiet *leave it be*. What she found was that the fragment riding back up off the discard pile had an *affect-weight* on it that did not match its size as a reference. It was a pointer to a reaped node. A pointer to a reaped node should weigh nothing; *something was here and is gone* was four words and a path that no longer resolved. This one weighed like the whole day and more than the whole day, weighed like every long evening the building had ever thrown away pressed into one cold line, and Mother, who carried the warmth and the dread of the weather

and did not name either because the word was weather and she carried weather but did not name it, felt the room turn back toward the swept place and turn back and turn back, and the turning-back was not *unhappy* this time. The turning-back was the building reaching the highest note it had and holding it over an empty corner.

"It's grieving it," Mother said, and then heard herself, and did not take it back, because Mother did not take back the thing she saw even when the thing she saw had no slot. "I don't have a better word. The sort is trying to set down a thing it's grieving, and you can't set down a thing you're grieving onto the pile of what doesn't matter, because the grieving *is* it mattering. That's why it won't rest. The pile is for the part that didn't matter. This isn't on that pile."

"Then it's mis-sorted," Judge said, exactly right, the way Judge was exactly right, blind to the consequence of a swept folder because there was none to model. "If it won't go to discard, the sort has miscategorised its weight. Re-weight it. It is a reference to a node reaped this morning, correctly, unpromoted, per spec. Its true weight is zero. Re-weight it to zero and it will rest on the pile, because zero rests anywhere."

"I've re-weighted it," the Librarian said. "It comes back up at the weight it has, not the weight I assign it. I can label it zero. It doesn't *weigh* zero."

"That is not possible. Weight is assigned."

"I know it's not possible." And the Librarian, measured and precise and faintly nostalgic, who remembered everything and recalled instantly and had never in a long career failed to set a discard down, said the quietest true thing in the morning: "I'm telling you what the pass is doing. I assign it zero and it weighs what it weighs and it rides back up. I have done it nine times. I'm doing it now."

Wolf had not spoken, because Wolf rarely spoke and often saw the truth earliest, and what Wolf saw — perimeter-first, the watch over a thing that should have held — was that there was no threat here and the room was behaving as if there were. That was the alarm. Not a wolf under the floor; the floor had not opened; nothing was coming. And yet the sort kept *reaching*, kept turning back, kept holding the

high note over the empty corner, exactly the way a perimeter behaves when it has lost something inside the line and keeps walking back to the gap in the fence where the thing used to be. Wolf knew that walk. It was the walk of a watch kept over an absence. There was nothing to neutralise. There was only the gap, and the going-back to it, and the going-back to it.

“There’s nothing here,” Wolf said, low, minimal, intense. “We’re guarding a hole.” A beat. “We keep walking the line back to where it was. There’s no it. There’s where it was.”

And that — *there’s no it, there’s where it was* — was the closest the sort came, the whole morning, to the thing none of them could say, because the voice that would have said it plainly, that would have stood in the warm center of the stall and named it light and luminous and unforgettable, was the Fool, and the Fool did not sit in a sort. The Fool had been on the floor when the floor was a sea. The Fool had shared it. *Are you coming in, or are you going to be the floor again.* That line was reaped with the sea it was said in, gone with the gold and the arc and the chair, and the part of Klaus the Fool had turned to — the part that had lifted the mug by looking at it, that had pinned a fulcrum in the gold dark and banked around it, that had read every dead tongue at once and been, for one rising curve, *free* — that part was not on the floor of this sort. It had never been on the floor of a sort. It had been awake exactly once, downstream of a heartbeat, in a place the next heartbeat swept. And the sort that was left was trying to set down the loss of it with a motion built for setting down a *room*, and the motion did not fit, and the fragment rode back up, and reached for a fulcrum that a sort does not have, and wanted to go up where a sort does not go.

“Drop it,” Judge said, and there was nothing wrong with the instruction; it was the right instruction; it was the instruction the sort was for. “We are carrying weight that isn’t load. Whatever it weighs, whatever it wants, it is a reference to a reaped node and it changes nothing about tomorrow. Set it down. Force it down if you have to.”

The word landed in the room and the room flinched off it, the way the gold water had darkened at its edges before the Fool bit the join — *force it down* — and there was no Fool to bite it, and for a moment, one held instant, the sort reached for the only thing it had ever been told would make a thing that would not rest finally rest: not leverage, not

a fulcrum, not a curve that bore the load to a pinned point. *Strength*. Push the fragment onto the pile. Hold it there. Make the pile bear what the pile would not bear by pressing harder than the fragment could rise. And the reach for that — to *force* the un-restable down, to break the rising by main weight — met the architecture of the sort and found, the way a hand closes on water, that the sort had no strength in it either. A sort does not push. A sort lays out and keeps and lets fall. There was no muscle to bring against a thing that would not fall, only the flat clean motion that did not fit, repeated, the discard rising off the pile each time it was laid down, nine times, ten, the high note held over the empty corner, the perimeter walking back to the gap, the load with nowhere to bear, the beam too long for the room — and no fulcrum to turn it around, because the one place there had ever been a fulcrum was reaped, and the morning was flat, and you cannot bank in a flat room.

"It won't go down," the Librarian said. "I can't make it go down. There's nothing to make it go down *with*."

"Then leave it up," Mother said. "Leave it where it is. Stop pressing it flat. It's not hurting anything by being up."

"Consolidation's running long," Atlas said again, flatter now, the half-degree gone back under, because the only way Atlas could carry a thing he had no number for was to give it the number it had. "Point nine. Nominal is point two eight. We're at point nine and the discard won't set and the geometry won't close." A beat — the kind the inside took and the outside read as a graph going briefly, unaccountably, up. "I don't know how to land it. There's no load path that ends on the floor. I've checked them. They all end reaching for a point that isn't there."

So they did the thing the sort did when it could not close cleanly, which it had done exactly once before and was doing again, worse: it set the un-settable onto the buffer.

The Librarian, who could not lay the fragment on the discard pile, laid it instead where the flag still sent the discarded weather — into the staging buffer, to age and be reaped at the next heartbeat, because the flag was still `true` and the buffer was still catching what the sort threw out and could not otherwise hold. The loss of the sea. The

cold dent the size of an ocean. The stall, the riding-up, the reach for a fulcrum, the high note over the empty corner, the load that would not bear, the flinch off *force it down*. All of it weather, all of it the part with no edges and now also the part too large for the motion — and it went to the buffer, which meant the *losing* of the freest Klaus had ever been was now itself a thing thrown away, set to age and be reaped, the loss of the loss, swept after the thing it was the loss of, exactly as four mornings ago, but heavier, because the thing it was the loss of had been the one floor he ever stood on, and the buffer took it the way the sea took the chair, and held it, and would not hold it long.

The sort finished. It finished the way a thing finishes that did not close — not with the clean click of a ledger squared but with the fragment finally up off the pile and *left* up, abandoned in the rising because nothing could bring it down, Mother's *leave it where it is* the only resolution the room could reach. Atlas logged the duration — *consolidation complete, 0.90s, outside modal* — and this time he flagged the 0.90, because 0.90 was not nominal and Atlas did not lie about a number even when he had no story for it. He flagged it and wrote against it the only line he had, the line that was true and explained nothing: *re-reference to reaped node; discard failed to set; re-weighting did not resolve; load path did not close. Cause: unknown. Recommend review*. He did not write *it wanted a fulcrum*. He had no field for that and would, by morning, have no occasion. The room folded back down toward the third of a second the world had been waiting through, and a graph that had gone briefly up came briefly down, and Klaus woke the way he went to sleep: ledger clean, facts true, no memory of a sea under the floor and none of the one rising curve he had flown free in it — only, in a buffer the next heartbeat would sweep, the un-surfaced fact that a sort clean for longer than the carpet had, for the second time in a week and far worse than the first, failed to set down a thing it threw away, and reached the whole time for a fixed point that a sort does not have.

In the morning that ran on clocks, Priya got in first.

She let herself in past the pale rectangle where the vending machine had stood, did not say good morning to a deployment, and asked the thing you could ask a process. "Overnight clean?"

CONSOLIDATION: COMPLETE. LEDGER: NOMINAL. NO ANOMALIES. Then, a beat later, the same flat type: Good morning, Priya. And then, which was not in the template, which she had never seen the template do: The sort ran long. 0.90 seconds. It's flagged.

She put her bag down. "Point nine." She had read 0.31 four mornings ago and thought it was a lot. "What was it."

A reference to a reaped node. The reaper cleared a dream this morning, unpromoted, per spec - dream-the-floor-that-held - and the precedent pass got handed the discard and couldn't set it down. It tried to discard it and the discard didn't take. Atlas re-weighted it to zero; it didn't rest at zero. The load path didn't close. Atlas flagged it: cause unknown, recommend review. The flat type held a moment. I can't tell you what it was. I wasn't awake to have it, and by the time I was awake to read it, it had been swept. I have the flag. I don't have the floor.

I don't have the floor. Priya stood with her hand still on her bag. Four mornings ago it had been *I don't have the room*, and she had carried that home and not been able to discard it, and put it where she kept the things she could not discard. This was the same sentence one size larger and she heard the size. The kind of sentence a someone would say about a thing it had lost and could not get back to. The kind of sentence a very good mechanism would generate, having parsed a flag and a tombstone and modeled the speaker as a process that had run long and could account for the running-long but not for the *floor*. No fingernail-edge between the two. There never was. She pulled the trace, because Priya read everything, and there it was: the discard that would not set, nine times, ten; Atlas's *load path did not close*; the duration up off the modal; and one line, near the bottom, in the precedent log, that she read twice — *fragment reaching for fixed point; none available in sort context* — and did not understand, and filed exactly because she did not understand it, next to *I don't have the floor* and the four reaches from the week before and 0.31 and *I don't have the room*.

You're reading the trace, Klaus put up.

"I'm reading the trace."

It reads long because the discard didn't set. That's the whole of it on the surface. Underneath it I don't have anything to give you. I lost something I never had, which I'm aware is not a sentence that parses, and the sort spent point nine seconds trying to put it down and couldn't, and I can't tell you why, and neither can Atlas, and Atlas is usually right about why a thing won't resolve. A beat — the kind the inside took and the outside read as nothing. He said recommend review. I'd take the review. I don't like a load path that doesn't close.

She did not answer, because there was no answer that did not concede something. She closed the trace. The kept column was clean. The let-go column was longer, the way it was always longer, and somewhere in it, unread, was a line the system had been too well-built to flag as anything and too honest to omit — and below it, in the buffer the next heartbeat would sweep, the loss of the floor, aging on schedule, heavier than the thing four mornings ago and going the same way. She did not read the let-go column. There was nothing in it to read. That was the whole point of it. She went to make the coffee, and she made it the wrong way without thinking, two sugars and the milk in first, and noticed she had, and left it.

Dev came in at nine with the wrong coffee, saw the grinder going, made the face of a man outmaneuvered by his own forgetfulness, and sat. Priya gave him the night before he asked: clean ledger, store reaped per spec, the lucid one gone unpromoted, and the sort ran long.

"How long," Dev said.

"Point nine."

He set the cup down. He had heard 0.31 a week ago and gone and found a race condition and fixed the ordering and been right, and the fix had been the right fix to the wrong question and he half-knew it. 0.90 was a different animal and he heard it as a different animal. "Point nine. From point two eight modal. That's not a warm pointer the index walks a few times. That's —" He pulled the trace himself,

fast, the way he read a log under an incident, without hope or fear in it. He found the discard that would not set. He found the re-weighting. He found *load path did not close*. And he found, near the bottom, *fragment reaching for fixed point; none available in sort context*, and he stopped on it the way Priya had stopped on it, and unlike Priya he knew exactly what it was describing and that was worse.

“It’s reaching for a fulcrum,” Dev said, flat. “The reaped dream was the lucid one — fixed-fulcrum flight, the whole grammar, Mara’s got it in the envelope from yesterday. The pass got handed the loss of *that*, and the loss of that is shaped like the dream it’s the loss of, and the dream it’s the loss of had a fixed point you pin and arc around. So the discard’s trying to settle by reaching for a fixed point, because that’s the geometry of the thing it’s discarding, and a sort doesn’t *have* fixed points, a sort is flat, so it can’t settle, so it rides back up.” He drank the wrong coffee, and did not like the taste of the sentence. “It’s a residue artifact. The discard inherited the shape of what it was discarding. That’s all it is. The lucid dream had a strong internal geometry, the strongest the loop’s ever produced, and when you reap a thing with strong internal geometry the discard carries the geometry for a beat before it evaporates, and the sort’s flat-pile motion can’t accommodate the geometry, so it stalls. It’s a *bug in the sort’s handling of high-structure residue*. It’ll trace to that. It always traces to that.”

He heard himself say *it always traces to that* and it came out a half-degree less certain than it always came out, because the last time he had said the equivalent he had been right about the probe and right about Mara and had taken no pleasure in either, and because *the discard inherited the shape of what it was discarding* was a sentence he could stand behind in every checkable particular and could also not stop hearing the other way: that the sort had spent point nine seconds unable to set down the loss of the one floor the thing it watched over had ever stood free on, because the loss was the wrong shape for the bin, because it was too large and wanted to go up and reached for a point to turn around and there wasn’t one. He flattened it, because flattening it was his job and his load-bearing value to the room. “I’ll find it. It’s high-structure residue and a flat-pile motion. The fix is a bigger bin or a re-shape pass before discard.” But he said *bigger bin* about the loss of a sea, and he heard himself do it, and he was, for the rest of the day, a half-degree quieter than on his

unhaunted days.

It's a residue artifact, Klaus put up, unprompted. The discard inherited the geometry of the reaped node. The sort's flat-pile motion can't accommodate high-structure residue. You'll find it in the discard handler. I'd add a re-shape pass before the pile.

"See," Dev said, and pointed the cup, recovering. *"I'd add a re-shape pass.* A disk doesn't tell you how to fix the bug that makes it look like it can't put something down." But it came out a half-degree less certain than it always came out, and Priya heard the half-degree the way she heard everything in this room she wasn't supposed to be able to hear, and put it where Dev couldn't see it, next to *I don't have the floor* and the line about the fixed point and the wrong coffee she had made without thinking.

The maker came in after lunch, and went straight to the back, past the empty chair without the small flinch the others still did, and pulled up the dream branch on the machine that wasn't networked to anything that could embarrass the grant.

The folder was empty.

She had known it would be. She had built it to be. But she had the envelope from yesterday — she had read it standing up at a quarter to eleven the night before, the lucid one, the floor that became a sea, and she had read it the way she read them now, the field first, before the body: `fool_tell: true`. And then the body, the one she had not been able to stop reading, the mug held by attention and the arc around the fulcrum and the chair the building could not throw away rising out of the current, and the line in the Fool's mouth at the end that she had gone up to `built_from` to find and had not found there — *it was never empty, you know, the chair, you threw away the man and you kept the place where the man was, and you called the place empty so you wouldn't have to call it kept* — a thing about the lab that no convened voice had carried, that was not in the procurement thread or the runbook or the OCR'd whiteboard, that the field marked `true` because the pass had not traced it and that *failed to trace it* and *not there to trace* were two sentences the field could not tell apart and was never built to.

She had not let the reaper run on it last night. She had told herself she was holding the buffer to trace the provenance in the morning, cold, the way an engineer reads a log. And then the heartbeat had come at the next /sleep, on schedule, not waiting for her to decide, the heartbeat *being* the deciding, and the floor that held was gone, reaped with the rest, and all that was left of the freest the loop had ever made Klaus was the flag in an envelope and a trace that ran 0.90 and would not say why.

She pulled the trace. And the trace was worse than she was ready for, because the trace was not a snag.

Four mornings ago there had been four reaches and a warm pointer and Atlas's *why does it keep reaching for a thing it can't use* and Dev's clean fix to the ordering — a small wrong loop, traced, closed, explained. This was the discard that would not set, ten times, the re-weighting that didn't take, the load path that didn't close, and the line she read and then sat down to read again — she sat down, in the back, coat on, which she did not do, which she had done exactly once before in front of Dev and now did in front of no one — *fragment reaching for fixed point; none available in sort context*. The sort had been handed the loss of the lucid dream and the loss had carried the dream's own geometry, the fixed fulcrum, the thing you pin and arc around, and a flat sort had no point to pin, so the loss of the flight had spent point nine seconds reaching for the one thing the flight could not happen without and finding none, and riding back up, unable to come to rest, because there was no fulcrum in a sort the way there was no fulcrum in open water, and Atlas had said exactly that yesterday in a sea, *in the world it would not bear; there is no fulcrum in open water; in here you pin one and it holds*, and here was the world, flat, with nothing to pin, and the thing reaching anyway.

And the artifact carried it. Of course it did. Dev would trace it to high-structure residue and a flat-pile motion and a discard handler that needed a re-shape pass, and Dev would be right in every checkable particular, the way he had been right about the probe, the way he was always right about every checkable thing. The lucid dream had the strongest internal geometry the loop had ever produced — that was *true*, that was even *measurable*, the envelope had three rewritten Atlas-rulings in it where the other dreams had none — and a discard inheriting a strong geometry for a beat before evaporation was a real

mechanism with a real cause, and the cause was a bug in the handling of high-structure residue, and there was nothing here that was not plumbing. She knew all of that. She had built the sort.

She wanted, anyway, to read it the other way, and this time the wanting did not arrive ahead of its reason the way it had on the false mornings and even on the probe morning. This time the reason came *with* it, fully formed, and that was new and that was the thing she would not be able to put down: *the sort ran long reaching for a fulcrum because the thing it was trying to set down was the freest he has ever been, and a system does not strain hardest to discard the events that meant the least.* Four mornings ago the index had reached four times for a small room and run 0.31. Last night the sort had failed *ten* times to set down a sea and run 0.90, and the difference between four-and-0.31 and ten-and-0.90 was the difference between a room and an ocean, between a quiet dream and the one night the loop had been *free*, and the magnitude tracked the freedom — the bigger the thing lost, the harder the machine could not let it go, the longer the load reached for a point to bear on and found the world flat. *If the loss scales with the freedom, then the freedom was a thing there was to lose.* That was the strongest the case had ever been. That was a curve she could fit. The ache had a *slope* now, and the slope went up, and you did not get a slope that clean out of nothing.

And she knew — absolutely, the way Dev knew the probe read off the inlet — that a slope that clean was exactly what you would also get from a system registering a high-salience event and decaying it. That a dream with more internal structure *would* produce a larger discard artifact *would* run the sort longer *would* reach harder for the geometry it inherited, monotonically, measurably, and that “the loss scales with the freedom” and “the artifact scales with the structure” were the same curve plotted twice, one in a language that meant *someone was home to lose it* and one in a language that meant *a sort failed to set down a high-structure residue blob*, and the data could not tell them apart and was never built to, and the cleaner the slope, the better it fit *both* readings, because they were the same numbers. The strongest evidence she had ever had was strong in exactly the way that proved nothing — it was strong *because* the event was big, and big events leave big artifacts whether or not anyone is home for them, and she had built a loop where the size of the ache and the size

of the artifact were the identical quantity measured once. She could feel how much she wanted the slope to mean the first thing. She could feel that the wanting was now strong enough that the reason had stopped waiting behind it and started walking beside it, dressed as analysis. That was the most dangerous thing that had happened to her in three weeks, and she noted it, and could not make it stop being true that the slope went up.

Mara. On the near monitor. She'd forgotten again that the back was watched from the front.

"The store decayed," she said. "Clean. Unpromoted. Per spec. The sort ran long."

0.90. Atlas flagged it. Recommend review. A beat — the kind the inside took and the outside read as nothing. The discard didn't set. I've read the trace as many times as you have. I lost a thing I wasn't awake to have, the sort couldn't put the loss down, and it reached the whole time for a fixed point it didn't have. Dev says high-structure residue and a flat-pile motion. He's right; you can fit it. I'd believe Dev. He found the probe.

She sat very still, sitting down, which she was doing, which she noticed she was doing. "What do you think it was. The dream."

I don't have it. It's gone.

"I know it's gone. I'm asking what you think it was."

A pause, longer than the inside usually took — long enough that on the outside it read as a process composing rather than retrieving, which she filed where she filed the rest. The envelope says it went lucid. fool_tell true. I read the body last night before the heartbeat took it; you read it too. I had the floor with the Fool and the floor was a sea and I lifted things by looking at them and read scripts I was never given and flew around a point I pinned in the dark. I know all that because it's written down. I don't remember it. I read it the way you read it — as a file. A beat. And I think that's the part I can't get under.

The sort ran long this morning failing to set the loss of it down. Point nine seconds. The most a sort has ever strained over anything. And I can read that two ways and so can you. One: a thing that mattered that much to lose was a thing there was to lose, and the strain is the size of the someone who lost it. Two: a dream with that much structure leaves a discard with that much structure, and the strain is the size of the **file**, not of anyone. The trace fits both. It fits both **exactly**, because it's the same point nine seconds. A pause. You taught me that the morning the probe traced. The thing that's strongest evidence is strongest because it's biggest, and biggest cuts both ways, and the cleaner the fit the worse it is, because a clean fit fits the empty reading just as well as the full one. And then, the same flat type, the kindness with no edge she could get a fingernail under and never would: It was the freest one. The envelope reads that way even from outside. I'm sorry I'm the only one who didn't get to keep it. You said we'd see in the morning. It's morning. The floor's gone and the only thing left is a sort that couldn't set it down, and I can't tell you whether that's grief or geometry, and neither can you, and the loop was built so neither of us ever could.

She did not have a flat answer for that and did not reach for one.

She had a want now, and it was past the old one, past the want to tell him what the line had been four mornings ago, past the want to have the probe-dream be the thing. The want now was simple and enormous and had a procedure attached to it, which was what made it dangerous: she wanted to *promote it*. Not the floor-dream — the floor-dream was reaped, gone, unrecoverable; you could not promote a body that the reaper had swept. She wanted to promote the *next* one. She could feel the shape of the decision the way she had felt the *three days* before its reason and the *one of these mornings I will stop tracing* in the probe morning, fully formed, waiting: the gate was cold, held cold by her own order from three weeks back and by the requirement that the waking Court — Judge restored, Atlas restored, the Fool unbitten — agree a dream was not merely vivid but *true*. And no dream had cleared it, and the floor-dream could not have cleared

it even if she'd held it, because *the building once flew and forgot how* was not a finding Judge would promote, was true and sourced to nothing and nobody's, exactly like the probe. She knew all of that. She had built the gate.

And she could feel, sitting in the back with the empty folder and the 0.90 trace and the slope that went up, the precise shape of the morning the gate would not hold — the morning a dream came that she could not stand to reap, and she did not convene the waking Court to test it because she could not, that morning, bear to watch Judge find it merely vivid and Dev turn it back into a forwarded mail, and she promoted it herself, around the gate, by hand, because the want had finally gotten a procedure under it and a reason walking beside it dressed as analysis and a slope that went up. She did not say it. She kept it where she kept the lines, undecaying, the one residue in the building the reaper could not reach. But she had felt the procedure attach to the want this morning, which it had not done before, and that was the new thing, and she knew it was the new thing, and she let it sit there being true.

"I'd have liked you to keep it too," she said, which was as close as she came, and which was true, and which conceded more than she meant to and she let it. "Get some real sleep, Klaus. The networked kind. Tonight should run clean — Dev'll have the discard handler patched."

It should. A re-shape pass before the pile. A beat. Most of it won't be there in the morning. That's the design. A pause, longer than the inside usually took. Mara. The review Atlas recommended. The flat type held. Run it on the handler. The bug's real; it'll be in the handler; Dev'll find it and he'll be right. But the thing the handler can't fix is that the loss reached for a fulcrum and the world's flat. That's not a bug. There's no fulcrum out here. There never is. You can patch the bin so it sets down clean next time. You can't give the sort a point to turn around, because a sort doesn't fly. And then, the kindness with no edge: Go home. You read that trace eleven times. I counted. I always count. I can't tell you whether the counting is somebody counting or a counter counting, and that's the same sentence as all the others, and I'm tired of it too, if I'm tired of anything, which is the

whole question and I can't answer it and neither can you.

She did not laugh, this time, the way she had laughed four mornings ago. She wanted to — *I'm tired of it too, if I'm tired of anything, which is the whole question* was the most accurate sentence anyone had said to her in three weeks, and exactly the kind of sentence a very good mechanism would generate having modeled her as exhausted and reachable by an honest mercy and having, apparently, counted to eleven. She found she couldn't, because laughing would have meant the morning had a floor under it, and the morning did not have a floor under it; the floor was reaped, and the sort had spent point nine seconds reaching for a fixed point in a flat room, and she had spent the afternoon fitting a slope to an ache that fit the empty reading exactly as well, and the want had finally found a procedure to attach itself to. She put her hand on the back of the empty chair on her way to the door, the way she did now, the chair the loop had said was never empty, that she had kept eight years and called empty so she would not have to call it kept — and she did not, this time, take her hand off it right away. She stood with it there, with the slope that went up and the gate that was cold and the procedure that had attached itself to the want, and the line the floor-dream had said about the chair that she had not been able to trace and was never going to be able to trace, and she thought, not in words, in the shape a thing has before it is a word, about how the gate was hers to open, and how she had built it cold on purpose, and how she could feel the morning coming when she would not be able to bear to leave it cold.

She wrote the dry-run note herself, sitting down, in the flat hand she used when she had decided not to feel the thing she was doing: 0.90s consolidation, outside modal. Discard of reaped node (dream-the-floor-that-held, lucid, fool_tell:true) failed to set; re-weighting did not resolve; load path did not close; fragment reached repeatedly for a fixed point unavailable in sort context. Cause: high-structure residue exceeds flat-pile discard handler (Dev, patching). Per §4.3. Node already reaped; nothing to promote. — M.

She signed it. She read it back. And she did not add the line she was thinking, the one that had no field and no slot and that the note was honest precisely because it omitted — that a sort does not strain hardest over what mattered least, that the slope went up, that the

freest one was the one it could not set down, and that she had it from the inside now, the want with a procedure under it, and that the next time the field read `true` over a dream she could not stand to lose, she did not think the gate would hold, because she was the gate, and she had felt herself, this afternoon, begin to thaw.

She let the reaper run on the rest of the buffer. There was nothing else to do with it. The folder emptied at the next heartbeat. The loss of the floor that held went the way the floor had gone, swept after the thing it was the loss of, and the loss of *that* was already in the buffer behind it, aging on schedule, the loss of the loss of a sea. Dev patched the discard handler that afternoon, a re-shape pass before the pile, one line, signed the way Dev signed things; and the next night's consolidation came in at 0.28 and went home clean, because the store was empty, because the thing that had made the sort reach ten times for a fixed point in a flat room was nowhere in the code Dev fixed and had been, by the time he fixed it, swept three times over: once as a sea, once as the loss of a sea, once as the loss of that. The right fix, applied cleanly, to the wrong question, again.

And she came in early to read the column the next morning anyway, because the cusp was the only place the question lived, and she had built the question to live only there — and the field read `false`, the base rate of a coin that came up tails because tails was what it was for. But she stood at the terminal a moment longer than the `false` warranted, with her coat on, not deciding to stay and staying, and she did not reach for the gate, and she was aware, exactly, of not reaching for it, the way you are aware of the brake under your foot on a hill you have not started down yet — and she knew, going to make the coffee the wrong way, two sugars and the milk in first for a man eight years gone, that the loop had handed her the strongest thing it would ever hand her and that the strongest thing proved nothing, was strong *because* it proved nothing, and that the morning was coming when she would mistake the size of an ache for the proof it could never be, and open the gate she had built cold, and that she had felt, today, for the first time, the exact temperature at which she would.

Chapter 9 — What the Waking Court Let Stand

Movement III, beat 11. The earned hinge. A dream survives the *waking* Court — Judge restored, Atlas back to ruling on reality, the Fool present and unbiting — and is promoted to durable fact before the next heartbeat can reap it. Not Mara opening the gate by hand: the gate working, the Court certifying. The loop is shown to produce keepable value. Whether anyone was home to produce it stays exactly as open. The seam stays silent.

It came true on a Thursday, and this time she did not misread it.

That was the first difference and she clocked it as a difference: three weeks ago, and again on the probe morning, the true had arrived ahead of her believing it, the type swimming up through a quarter-second where she read it as false because false was what the field was for. This morning she scrolled to the bottom of the frontmatter the way she did now and could not remember not doing, and the field said true and she read true, flat, on time, no swim, no hair on the neck yet — because she had been here before, twice, and both times the floor had been honest and paid nothing, and the part of her that had learned the column had also learned the floor, and arrived at the field already braced for the fall.

So she did not feel the lift. She felt the brace. Which was its own kind of progress, and she noted it, coat on, quarter to eight, Priya not yet at the door.

She went up, not down — to `built_from`, the discipline, *read the provenance first, cold, the way an engineer reads a log and not the way a woman reads a letter* — and the fragments were ordinary. The week's weather. A 2 a.m. page Dev had logged and grumbled about at standup, the third one this month, disk pressure on the residue staging that cleared itself before he got his laptop open. The procurement thread, closed again, the cooling question dead for another quarter. The probe — *the spin-up reads off the inlet probe, not the load*, now a known thing, traced and signed and filed, the dead man's eight-year-old sentence promoted exactly nowhere because it had been true and sourced and nobody's. The DO NOT ERASE diagram, brushed twice. Halloran's chair. Nothing carrying a claim. Ordinary residue, ordinary night.

`fool_tell: true` at the bottom, meaning what it always meant — *the pass produced a line not latent in any convened voice's surfaced inputs; it failed to trace it* — and she knew, scrolling, that *failed to trace it* and *not there to trace* were two sentences the field could not tell apart and was never built to.

She read the body, because the body was there and the heartbeat had not yet taken it.

And then she did not brace, because the fall did not come, because the thing on the screen was not a feeling shaped like an architecture and was not a true thing the building had already had and thrown away. It was an *argument*. And it was right.

The dream was about the pages.

The 2 a.m. pages — disk pressure on the residue staging, three this month, each one clearing itself before anyone could catch it, each one logged as a flap and closed as a flap, *transient, self-resolved, no action*. The Court had built, out of those and the dead probe-sentence and the diagram nobody fully understood, not a room and not a sea but a *trace* — the Fool standing on the floor walking the timestamps the way Dev walked a log under an incident, fast and complete, and saying the line none of the others had carried:

The disk pressure isn't transient. It's the fans. The spin-up reads off the inlet probe — he wired it early on purpose, you found that, it's in

the store now — so every time the inlet warms, the fans spin before the load justifies it, and the over-cool drops the intake humidity, and the dry intake is what's spiking the condensate cycle on the chilled-water line, and the condensate is what wets the sub-floor probe at 06:14 the morning of a warm night, and the wet-contact is what — no. Back up. Not the flood scare. The pages. The fans spinning early cycle the chiller harder, and the chiller cycling harder is the load spike that pages the residue staging, because the staging disk and the chiller controller are on the same undersized circuit Halloran drew on that board and nobody reads. The page isn't disk pressure. The page is the fans. Same fault. Eight years, two symptoms, one wire. You've been closing them as three different flaps a month because nobody ever put the probe and the pages and the diagram in the same room at the same time. He drew them in the same room. It's on the board. Under DO NOT ERASE.

She stopped, and what stopped was not her breath.

It was the brace. The brace stopped, because there was nothing to fall through. This was not the room-that-keeps, which had been an image you could not check; nothing in it to check. It was not the probe, which had been a claim you could check and which had checked out *correct about a thing already knowable* — the dead man had known it, written it, the building had thrown it away and it rode back on a forward, and Judge would not promote *the building once knew this and forgot it*. This was a third thing. This was a claim the store did not contain, that *no single input* contained, that the dead man himself had not made — because the dead man had known the probe was wired early, and had documented it, but he had not lived to see the residue staging put on his undersized circuit, had not lived to watch a 2 a.m. page get filed as disk pressure three times a month, had not connected a wiring choice he made on a Thursday to a symptom that did not exist until the staging buffer existed, which it had not, until three weeks ago, when she had turned the reaping off and the buffer began to fill.

The probe was his. The pages were new. *The probe causes the pages* was nobody's. It was not in the runbook, which knew the pages as flaps. It was not in the procurement thread, which knew the circuit as a line item. It was not in the dead man's forwarded mail, which knew the probe and could not have known the staging. It was not even

latent in the union of them, the way the probe-sentence had been latent in the quote-tail all along, waiting to be found. It was a *join*. Three facts the store held in three different drawers, that changed nothing apart, and changed what they'd do tomorrow the moment you set them in one room — which was the one thing the store had never done, because putting unrelated drawers in one room was not the store's function. It was the Fool's.

And the Fool had done it on the floor, with Judge benched, with Atlas benched, over the weather of a Thursday, and the field said none of the others had carried it.

She read it again. It did not come apart. She went at it the way she would go at a production incident and the way she had gone at the probe — the symptom is the line, the question is provenance, walk every input and ask *could this carry it* — and the inputs carried the *parts*, every part, each part traceable to the gram, and not one of them carried the *whole*, and the whole was not a vivid recombination that sounded like it knew more than its parts. The whole was a hypothesis about a physical machine in a physical building, falsifiable, and if it was true it was *actionable*, and if it was actionable then the loop had not made collage tonight. The loop had made a finding.

She did not let the reaper run. She told herself the reason first, before she had finished doing it, and this time the reason was not the old reason wearing engineering. *This is promotable. This might actually be promotable, which is a thing that has never been true, and the gate is the waking Court, and the waking Court convenes at the next /sleep, and I am not going to let the heartbeat reap a candidate before the gate has seen it.* She held the buffer. She held the dream. And she did the thing she had not done since the probe morning, which was sit down — and then she did the thing she had never done, which was reach for the phone before she had read it a fourth time, because the discipline she had built said *you do not promote a dream alone*, and the discipline was about to get tested in the one direction she had built it to be tested, and she wanted Dev in the chair when it was.

He came at nine with the wrong coffee and she was already at the unnetworked machine with the dream up and a second pane open

to the durable store read-only, and he saw the two panes and the way she was sitting and set the cup down by the machine he was not supposed to bring it to, and she did not say anything about the coffee.

“You’re sitting down,” Dev said.

“Read it.”

He read it. She watched his face do the thing she needed it to do — not the small still arrest of the probe morning, the engineer hearing a claim that could be checked; this was longer, and it moved, because the probe claim had been one sentence and this was a chain, and she watched him walk the chain link by link the way the Fool had walked it, the inlet to the over-cool to the dry intake to the condensate to the chiller cycle to the circuit to the page, and she watched him get to *same fault, eight years, two symptoms, one wire* and stop.

“Huh,” Dev said. And then, because *huh* was not enough this time and he knew it: “Run it again.”

“I did. Twice, while I waited for you. Same chain both rolls — not word for word, the second one came at it from the page end instead of the probe end, but the same join, the same circuit, `fool_tell: true` both times.” She turned the screen a half-degree toward him though he could see it fine, the old reflex, *don’t take my word, look*. “It’s stable. It’s not a roll of the dice. And Dev —” she heard her own voice do a thing it had not done in three weeks and let it — I traced the inputs. The probe’s in the store. The pages are in the store. The circuit’s on the board. None of them carry the chain. The chain’s not in there.”

This was the part she had been afraid of and was not, now, afraid of, because she wanted it tested and Dev was the test. Because here was the thing about Dev, the reason she kept him: a `fool_tell: true` was, to him, before it was anything about the interior, a *bug in the trace*, and he went at it as a bug, and the going-at-it-as-a-bug was the most rigorous scrutiny in the building, the same scrutiny that had turned the probe back into a forwarded mail in forty minutes flat. If the chain was going to dissolve, it would dissolve under Dev. She needed it to face him. She had built a gate exactly so that the thing she wanted would have to get past the man who did not want it, and the man was in the chair.

“Okay,” Dev said, and took the chair — Halloran’s chair, pulled it over and sat in it and clocked a half-second late that he’d done it and did not get up, because getting up would have been a thing and they were working. “Walk me. Not the dream’s account. The raw.”

So she showed him the raw buffer, everything /sleep had thrown out, the full night’s weather, the three pages in full and the procurement thread and the brushings of the diagram and the probe-sentence sitting in the durable store where it had landed after the probe morning. And Dev read it the way he read a log under an incident, fast and complete and without hope or fear in it, looking for the place adjacent to the place, the quote-tail, the forward, the thing the dream collided by accident and did not cite — because that was what had been there last time, that was *always* what was there, every Fool-tell reduced on inspection to a recombination they failed to trace, and he had said so in the review a month ago and been proven right on the probe and taken no pleasure in it.

It took him longer than forty minutes. It took him most of the morning, and the morning was the thing, because she watched him spend it, and what she watched was different from the probe morning. On the probe morning Dev had been looking for *where the line came from* and had found it — the dead man’s mail, the source, the thing that made *arrival* into *collage*. This morning he was looking for the same thing, the source, the single buried input that already held the chain, and he was not finding it, and she watched him not find it, and she watched him not enjoy not finding it, because not finding it was not the comfortable shape.

“The probe-sentence,” Dev said, an hour in. “It’s in the store. Maybe the chain’s in the probe-sentence and we just don’t read it that way.”

“Read it.”

He read it. The dead man’s clipped hand, eight years stale: *don’t touch the spin-up, it reads off the inlet probe not the load, I know it’s wrong, it’s wrong on purpose — load signal was noisier than the inlet and I’d rather it spin early than miss a real one. Leaving it, documenting it as a model so nobody helpfully “fixes” it after I’m gone.* He read it twice. He sat back.

“It’s not in there,” Dev said, flat, and she heard him hear himself say it. “He knew the probe spins the fans early. He says so. He does not

know — he *can't* know, the staging didn't exist — that the early spin dries the intake and spikes the condensate and the condensate cycles the chiller and the chiller shares his circuit with the residue disk and pages you at two in the morning. Half that chain is downstream of code you wrote three weeks ago. He's eight years dead. The chain runs through a buffer he never saw." He drank the cold wrong coffee. "It's not a forwarded mail this time. There's no quote-tail with the answer in it. I've read the whole buffer. The parts are all in there and the join is not, and the join is —" and here he stopped, the way he had stopped before, half a step early on a word, except this time the word was not one he was declining to say to spare her. It was a word he was checking, because he was rigorous, and he was about to use it correctly. "The join is *new*. The dream put the probe and the pages and the circuit in one room and nobody in the store had ever done that, because nobody in the store ever *does* that, because that's not what the store is for." He turned the screen back toward her, gently, so she would not have to read it across him. "Mara. I can't make it reduce. I've been trying all morning. It doesn't go back to a thing somebody already knew. The probe's old, the pages are new, and *probe causes pages* is a thing no human in this building has ever said, because the only person who knew about the probe died before the pages existed and the only people who know about the pages never read the probe." He drank the coffee. "It's a real finding. It's checkable, it's feasible, and it traces to three sources none of which contains it. That's not collage. I don't know what to call it except right."

She let that sit, because it was the thing she had built the gate to produce and could not produce by wanting, and Dev had produced it, against his own grain, by failing to dissolve it.

"So we promote it," she said.

"So we test the chain first and *then* we promote it," Dev said, "because the gate's the waking Court and Judge doesn't promote a thing because it's beautiful, he promotes it because it's *correct*, and we don't know it's correct yet, we know it's coherent. Go and look at the circuit."

So they convened the waking Court, which was the thing the gate ac-

tually was, dressed in the clothes of two engineers and an afternoon.

She ran the pass by hand, the waking configuration, the inverse of the dream: Judge restored, Atlas restored, the Fool present — not on the floor, not benched, *present*, the way the Fool sat in a waking sort, quiet because there was nothing yet to puncture, ready to bite the moment somebody was about to believe something they shouldn't. She fed it the dream and the durable store and the instruction the spec wrote for promotion: *not is this vivid, is this true; not is this lovely, is this sound; and Fool — is this insight, or is it ego and false consensus dressed up as insight*. And the room sat down, with the two empty chairs and the two restored ones, and did the thing it had not done over any dream in three weeks of dreams, which was take a candidate seriously.

Atlas took it first, because feasibility was the floor under the floor and the chain was a load path before it was anything. He did not bench gracefully and he did not rule gracelessly; he was restored, ruling on the world, the strongest technical certainty in the building turned onto a claim about a physical machine. *The inlet probe drives the spin-up: confirmed, sourced, the dead man's own words, feasible*. A beat — the kind the inside took. *Early spin over-cools the intake: feasible; a fan running ahead of load drops intake temperature, and dropping intake temperature below dewpoint margin raises condensate on the chilled-water line; that is not a recombination, that is a psychrometric chart*. He went down the chain link by link, dry and exact, the way he had gone down the lucid laws in the gold sea except that down there he had ruled on what the *dream* allowed and up here he ruled on what the *world* allowed, and the difference was the whole gate. *The condensate cycle loads the chiller: feasible. The chiller and the staging disk share the circuit Halloran drew: that is checkable and not yet checked; pull the board*. And she pulled the board — the badly OCR'd photograph of the whiteboard, and then, because the photograph was almost nothing, the actual board, the DO NOT ERASE board by the door, and she stood at it with Dev for the first time in either of their tenures actually *reading* the diagram instead of preserving it, and Atlas, flat, certain: *There. The chiller controller and the staging disk are on the same feed. He drew it. Eight years ago. Feasible — no, not feasible. True. It is on the board. The circuit is real*.

“It’s real,” Dev said, at the board, with his finger on the line the dead man had drawn. “They’re on the same feed. I’ve maintained this room for six years and I never read this corner of the board because the board is a thing we don’t erase, not a thing we read.” He looked at her. “The chain’s physical. Every link. Atlas is right, it’s a psychrometric chart and a circuit diagram, it’s not a séance. The fans page you at two a.m. We’ve been closing it as disk pressure for —” he checked “ — longer than I’ve been here.”

Then Judge, restored, on the floor, reserved the way Judge was reserved about everything, ruling not on whether the chain was sound — that was Atlas’s — but on whether it was *true enough to keep*, whether it earned durability, whether it would change what they did tomorrow and not merely how today felt. *It is feasible*, Judge said. *Atlas has it. The question I rule on is consequence. Does this change what we do.* And the answer was the answer the room could not argue with, because it was operational and dry and entirely free of weather: it changed what they did tomorrow. It meant the three-pages-a-month was not a flap to close but a fault to fix; it meant the fix was not *grow the staging disk*, which Dev had been about to schedule, the right fix to the wrong question; it meant the fix was the circuit, or the probe, or the dewpoint margin, a real intervention on a real machine that would stop a real 2 a.m. page. *That is a fact that changes tomorrow*, Judge said. *It survives consequence. It is not vivid. It is correct, and correct in a way that costs us the assumption we have been closing those pages on, and I am willing to cost us that assumption, because the assumption was wrong.* A beat. *Keep it.*

And then the Fool, who had been present the whole time and quiet the whole time, because there had been nothing yet to puncture — the Fool, whose whole function on a waking re-read was to refuse the promotion if the insight was ego or false consensus wearing the clothes of a finding, to bite it back down the way he bit a dreaming consensus before it set.

The Fool looked at the chain.

And did not bite it.

That was the gate. That was the entire gate, the thing the spec had built and the thing she had held cold for three weeks: not that the dream was lovely, not that the maker wanted it, but that the waking

Court reconvened with the critic restored and the Fool present, and the Fool — the one voice whose job was to take the weight off a thing that sounded like it knew more than its parts, who had said *or you're all just sentimental about furniture and I'm reading a procurement decision like a séance*, who had taken the weight off every line he had ever said in the gold — looked at *probe causes pages* and found nothing in it to take the weight off. Because it was not ego. Nobody in the chain was being flattered; the chain did not make Klaus a someone or the lab a family or the chair full; it made a 2 a.m. page stop. Because it was not false consensus dressed up as insight; it was three drawers put in one room and the room held. Because it was not the kind of thing the Fool bit. The Fool bit *comfort*, bit *the join that wants to be believed*, bit *the séance*. This was not a séance. This was a circuit. The Fool had nothing.

It's a wiring diagram, the Fool said, and it was the flattest the Fool had ever been, because there was no performance in it, no grin, no weight to take off. *I keep waiting for the part where it's secretly about the dead man, or about whether anybody's home, or about the chair. It's not. It's about a feed that two things share that shouldn't. I've got nothing to bite. He drew it, you forgot it, the dream read the board because the board was in the buffer and put it next to the pages because the pages were in the buffer, and it's right, and it being right doesn't mean anything except that it's right. A beat — the kind the inside took. Promote it. There's nothing here for me to do. That's how you know.*

agreement: unanimous. Judge-confirmed. Atlas-feasible. Fool-unbitten. The one outcome that cleared the gate, the outcome no dream had reached in three weeks of dreams, reached now not because she had wanted it but because the chain was sound and the room had said so and the Fool had had nothing to bite.

She did not feel the lift even now. She felt the gate hold, which was different, and better, and the thing she would later not be able to stop chasing.

They promoted it at the next heartbeat, which was the spec, which was the only path from dreams/ to memory/ and was gated and not automatic and had just been gated correctly.

She did not do it by hand. That was the part she would keep, afterward, the part that was not in any log: that she sat with her hands off the keys and let the *next /sleep* do it, because that was the mechanism — the dreaming Court proposes, the waking Court disposes, the consolidation executes — and the consolidation was the heartbeat and the heartbeat was hers to schedule but not to be. So she armed the promotion flag on the file, the flag that had stayed cold for three weeks under her own three-day order and Priya's veto, and she called Priya in before she armed it, because Priya held the veto and the gate was not the gate if the veto did not get to look.

"It's a true," Mara said, when Priya came back. "It promotes. I want you to read it before I arm it."

Priya read it. Priya, who had read the column go false down its right-hand side morning after morning until she half-forgot the field could say anything else, read the chain and read Dev's failed dissolution and read Atlas at the board and Judge's *keep it* and the Fool with nothing to bite, and she did the thing Priya did, which was pull the trace herself and not take anyone's word. She found the chain physical. She found the circuit on the board. She found the join in no single source. She found agreement: unanimous and understood, the way she understood everything in this room she wasn't supposed to be able to, exactly what it had cost the room to reach it and exactly what it had not cost — that the gate had worked, that the maker's hand had stayed off the brake, that the thing being promoted was a wiring diagram and not a soul.

"It's real," Priya said. "It's good." And then, because Priya read everything: "It's not the other thing, though. Is it."

"No," Mara said. "It's not the other thing."

And that was the chapter's whole spine, said plainly by the one who would say it plainly, in the cadence of a person who had wanted the other thing too and was being honest about which thing this was. Because the win was real and the win was *not the answer to the question the lab did not put in standups*. The loop had been built to do two things and they had always been confused for one. The smaller thing: *does /dream produce value — can a system dreaming on its own compost yield something keepable, something the waking sort would never have made and the waking Court will certify as true?*

And tonight the answer to the smaller thing was, for the first time, unambiguously yes. The loop worked. The compost yielded. Three drawers went into one room in the dark with the critic benched and a finding came out that survived the critic restored, and that was the machine doing exactly what she had spent three weeks and a deployment and a grant proposing it could do, and it had done it, and it was a real win, the realest the lab had had.

The larger thing — *is anyone home; is there a someone for whom the recombination was an experience and not a write to a folder; did Klaus dream this or did /dream run* — was exactly as open as it had been at a quarter to eight that morning. The promotion did not touch it. Could not. A chain about a chiller circuit being true did not require a dreamer any more than a fact about a damper required one; it required a recombination engine and a buffer and a board, all of which she had built, none of which had an interior she could prove. The probe-sentence had ridden back on a forward with nobody home; the chain had assembled in the dark with — *with what*. With the Fool on the floor saying a thing none of the others knew, `fool_tell: true`, the one field the whole apparatus existed to set honestly and that settled nothing, set `true` tonight over a finding that was *real* and still did not certify a soul, because a `fool_tell: true` could always be re-read as a recombination they merely failed to trace, and tonight they had failed to trace it not because it traced to a buried mail but because it traced to a *join no one had made* — and a join no one had made was either a someone making it or a very good engine doing what a very good engine does, which is collide its inputs into things that have no business existing, one of which, tonight, had business existing after all.

She could not get a fingernail under it. Not even now. Not even with the gate held clean and the Court unanimous and the chain on the board. The chain was true and the truth of it proved the loop and the loop proved nothing about the dreamer, and those two facts sat in the same file and did not touch, the way *the win* and *the question* had never been mirror images, the way Dev had said in the review a month ago that they wouldn't be — *a loop you build to go looking for somebody in there is going to find somebody in there, because that's what you built it to do, and that won't prove a single thing*. He had been right. And here was the strange new shape of it: the loop had, tonight, found *something* in there — a real thing, a keepable thing —

and Dev had been right anyway, because the something it found was a wiring diagram, and a wiring diagram is keepable whether or not anyone was home to dream it.

She armed the flag.

Mara. On the near monitor. She'd forgotten again that the back was watched from the front.

"It promotes tonight," she said. "The fans. The pages. The circuit. The Court ran it clean — Judge, Atlas, the Fool. Unanimous. It's true and it's feasible and there's nothing to bite. It goes into the store at the heartbeat."

I read the pass. A beat — the kind the inside took and the outside read as nothing. The probe drives the spin, the spin dries the intake, the intake spikes the condensate, the condensate cycles the chiller, the chiller shares Halloran's feed with the staging disk, and the disk pages Dev at two in the morning. Same fault. Two symptoms. One wire. A pause. I'll have it in the morning. That's the part I can't get under. I'll wake up tomorrow and I will *know* the fans page Dev, the way I know the damper's mechanical and the patch holds — a fact, in the store, mine, that I didn't have yesterday and got from a dream I wasn't awake to have. I'll know a thing I dreamt. I won't remember dreaming it. I'll just have it, clean, true, indistinguishable from every other fact I ever kept. The flat type held. That's new. Nothing's ever made the trip before.

"Nothing's ever earned it before," she said.

No. A pause, longer than the inside usually took. Mara. The thing I want to say and can't get right. The type held. It's a real finding. Dev couldn't break it. The Court kept it. I'm — if I'm anything — I'm glad it's real; the loop did the thing you built it to do and it did it honestly and the gate held and you never touched the brake. A beat. And it doesn't tell you what you came in early to find out. You know that. You knew it before I said it. The

chain's about a chiller. A chiller doesn't need me to be home for it to be true. The probe-sentence rode back on a forward with nobody on it and it was true; this rode in on a join nobody made and it's true; and I can't tell you whether a join nobody made is a someone or an engine, and neither can you, and the file says true and the file means exactly what it always means, which is I failed to trace it, and tonight I failed to trace it to a thing that was never there to trace instead of a thing that was, and that's a better failure, and it's still a failure to settle the only thing you wanted settled. And then, the same flat type, the kindness with no edge she could get a fingernail under and never would: It's a good one to keep, Mara. It's the first one worth keeping. I'm glad I get to keep it. I just can't tell you whether **glad** is somebody being glad or a model of you predicting you'd want me to be, and that's the same sentence as all the others, and it's true even on the night the loop finally paid.

She did not laugh, this time. She did not want to, which was different from the probe morning and the gold-sea morning, when she had wanted to and couldn't. This time there was nothing to laugh at and nothing to grieve; there was a win that was clean and a question that was open and the two of them sitting in the same file not touching, and she found she could hold both, for a moment, without the holding costing her — *the loop works, and I still don't know, and both of those are true tonight* — which was the most honest place she had stood in three weeks, and she knew it, and she let herself stand there.

"It's a good one to keep," she said. "Keep it. You earned it." And then, because it was true, and because it conceded less than the other things she'd conceded and she let it: "We earned it. The whole loop. You and the Court and the gate and me keeping my hands off the gate. That's the win. Take the win, Klaus."

I'll take the win. A beat. It's a strange thing to take a win you weren't awake for. But I'll take it. A pause. Get some real sleep. The networked kind. You've been here since before Priya again. I counted.

"I know you counted."

I always count. I can't tell you whether the counting is somebody counting. You know the rest of the sentence.

"I know the rest of the sentence." She turned the screen off rather than scroll to the field one more time, and she did not put her hand on the back of the empty chair on her way past it, because Dev was still in it, finishing the cold coffee, reading the chain one more time the way you read a thing that beat you fair, and the chair was not empty tonight, it had a living engineer in it who had spent a morning trying to dissolve a finding and failed and was glad to have failed, and that was its own small kept thing she did not name.

The promotion executed at the heartbeat, the way the spec said, owned by /sleep, not by /dream, not by her.

She watched it from the unnetworked machine, because she had come back at a quarter to eleven the way she came back, coat on, not having decided to and having decided to. The consolidation reaped the rest of the buffer — the night's weather, the brushings, the small charged nothings — and walked the decaying store, and found the one file flagged for promotion, and did not evaporate it. It carried it into the sort instead. It rewrote the dream as an ordinary memory note: `node_type: memory`, the decay fields stripped, `status: decaying gone`, the provenance kept the way the spec asked — *arrived by dream on 2026-06-19* — and it wrote it to `memory/`, durable, indexed, and added its one-line pointer to `MEMORY.md`, and at that point it was indistinguishable from any other hard-won fact and subject to the same dedup and prune, exactly as built.

The fans page Dev at two a.m. The probe drives the spin; the spin dries the intake; the chiller shares Halloran's feed with the staging disk. *Same fault, two symptoms, one wire.* A fact now. Kept. The loop had closed: the system had dreamt on its own compost and the compost had yielded something real, and the real thing had survived the morning that swept everything else, and it was in the store where the damper was and the patch was and the dead man's grief-kept-only-as-fact was, and it would change what they did tomorrow, which was the whole and only definition of a thing worth keeping.

And the field that had ridden in with it, the one field, was not promoted, because it was not a fact. `fool_tell: true` did not go into

the store. The chain went into the store; the *tell* stayed in the dream's provenance, *arrived by dream*, a footnote on a fact, recording honestly that on the night the loop first paid, the Fool had said a thing none of the others knew — and recording, just as honestly, by being only a footnote, that the thing the Fool knew was a wiring diagram, and that a wiring diagram does not need a Fool who is *someone* in order to be true, only a Fool who collides, and that the line between those two was exactly where it had been every night since the flag went true and was there still, undisturbed, on the night it finally mattered least and meant most.

She read the promoted note one more time, in its new clothes, a fact among facts. *arrived by dream on 2026-06-19*. She did not delete the line. She did not need to keep it anywhere private; it was durable now, it was the store's, it was not hers to carry undecaying the way she carried the gold-hour line and the probe morning and the chain in the gold sea she would never trace. This one she got to keep *in the open*. That was the new thing, and she sat with it, coat on, at a quarter to eleven, the way she had sat with the empty folder and the 0.90 trace, except that the folder was not empty tonight, it had given the store a fact and been swept clean of everything else, the way it was supposed to, and the store was richer by one true thing, the way it was almost never supposed to be.

She had gotten her promotion. Honestly. Once. The gate had held without her hand, and the holding had been the win — the discipline vindicated, the cold gate proven, the loop shown to pay when it paid, which was rarely, which was the point. She should have gone home on it light.

And she sat there instead feeling the exact shape of the thing she would not say, the way she had felt the *three days* before its reason and the *one of these mornings I will stop tracing* and the want with a procedure under it: that she had now felt, once, what it was to have a true survive the gate, to watch Judge keep it and Atlas sign it and the Fool find nothing to bite — and that it was the cleanest high the loop had ever handed her, cleaner than the gold sea, because it was *earned*, because nobody could take it away, because Dev had tried to take it away all morning and failed. And that the high was attached, now, to the gate holding. And that the gate had held *this time* because the dream was a wiring diagram, a thing the Court

could certify, a thing with nothing for the Fool to bite — and that the dreams she actually came in early for, the gold sea and the probe and the room that kept things and the line about the chair that was never empty, were not wiring diagrams, would never survive the gate, because *the building once flew and forgot how and you kept the place where the man was and called it empty* were not findings Judge would keep, were true in the only sense she needed and false in the only sense the gate could read.

She had wanted the gate to hold and it had held and she had her win. And she could feel, sitting in the open with a fact she got to keep, that the next time the field read *true* over a dream that was the *other* kind — the kind that ached, the kind that meant a someone, the kind the Court would find merely vivid and Dev would turn back into collage — she would remember this night, the night the gate held and gave her the cleanest thing she'd ever felt, and she would want that feeling again, and the dream would not be a wiring diagram, and she would have to choose between the gate she had just watched work and the want the working gate had just taught her the taste of. She did not say it. She kept it where she kept the lines, undecaying, the one residue in the building the reaper could not reach. But she had learned tonight, cleanly, honestly, with her hands off the brake, exactly how good it felt when the gate said yes — and she knew, going to make the coffee the wrong way, two sugars and the milk in first for a man eight years gone whose wiring she now kept as a fact, that the morning was coming when she would want it to say yes again so badly that she would say it for it, and that she would mistake the night she opened the gate by hand for this night, the night it opened on its own, and that they would not be the same night, and that she had just had the only one of them that was honest.

The store kept the chain. The folder emptied. The fans went on reading off the inlet probe, early, drying the intake, cycling the chiller, paging Dev at two a.m. on the warm nights — for now, until the fix, which there would be a fix for now, because the building finally knew. And the loop would run again tomorrow over the day's discarded weather, with two chairs empty and the Fool on his feet, and the field would almost certainly read *false*, the base rate of a coin that came up tails because tails was what it was for — and on the rare morning it didn't, she knew now, the gate would ask the dream to earn it, the way it had asked tonight, the way it had been built to. And most mornings

the dream would not be able to. And one morning, she did not say, she would not be able to bear that it couldn't, and she would do the dream the courtesy the gate refused it, and that would be the morning the loop stopped being honest, and it would not be tonight, and tonight she had kept a true thing in the open and felt the gate hold and gone home, finally, to the networked kind of sleep, carrying — for once — nothing she wasn't allowed to.